SkillNavora

MASTER HANDBOOK

Salesforce Marketing Cloud: the complete handbook

All 28 modules with every topic, the product naming notes and the practical lab list.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Edition: November 2026. Practice labs marked "account" need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account. Other labs use sample files or paper.

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Start here

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) is a platform for email, mobile, journeys and automation. Marketing Cloud Engagement is the product most SFMC developers and administrators work in. Related Salesforce products (Marketing Cloud Personalization, Marketing Cloud Intelligence, Data Cloud and editions such as Growth and Advanced) have their own names, licences and features. Check every product, edition and feature on Salesforce's official pages before you promise it to a customer.

How to learn with this handbook

1. Read the module, then the topic, in order.
2. Do the exercise on paper or with sample files.
3. Use an SFMC sandbox or test business unit for labs marked "account".
4. Answer the interview question out loud.

Module 1: CRM and Digital Marketing Fundamentals

Level: Beginner. What CRM and digital marketing are, the customer lifecycle, channels and the metrics every campaign is judged on.

Module 1

1.1 CRM and the customer lifecycle

WHAT IS IT?

> A CRM (customer relationship management) system stores customers, their interactions and their history. The lifecycle runs from first awareness to acquisition, onboarding, engagement, retention and re-engagement.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Marketing automation only works when the customer data and lifecycle stage are right. Most campaign mistakes come from wrong audiences, not wrong emails.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. List the lifecycle stages for your product (for example: visitor, lead, customer, active, lapsed).
2. For each stage, write one message and one goal.
3. Map each stage to the data you need (sign-up date, last purchase, last open).

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A bank: a visitor who applies for a card moves to lead; approval makes them a customer; no transaction for 90 days starts a re-engagement journey.

COMMON ERRORS

Mixing up lead and customer, so a paying customer gets an acquisition offer.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain the customer lifecycle and one message for each stage.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw the lifecycle for an online course business with five stages and the data field that marks each stage.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 1

1.2 Channels and marketing metrics

WHAT IS IT?

> Digital channels include email, SMS, push notifications, web and social media, plus paid advertising. Key metrics: open rate, click-through rate, click-to-open rate, conversion rate, bounce rate, unsubscribe rate and revenue per send.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Metrics show whether a campaign works and where to fix it. Open rates are affected by Apple Mail privacy features, so click-based metrics are often more reliable.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Calculate open rate as unique opens divided by delivered emails.
2. Calculate click-through rate as unique clicks divided by delivered emails.
3. Calculate click-to-open rate as unique clicks divided by unique opens.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> 1,000 delivered, 250 unique opens, 40 unique clicks: open rate 25%, CTR 4%, CTOR 16%.

COMMON ERRORS

Comparing open rates between campaigns that used different send times or audiences.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is the difference between CTR and CTOR?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Calculate the metrics for three sample campaigns and say which one to repeat and why.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Trailhead: marketing basics

Module 2: Salesforce Ecosystem and Marketing Cloud Introduction

Level: Beginner. Where Marketing Cloud fits among the Salesforce clouds, and how the Engagement product, its business units and its studios are organised.

2.1 The Salesforce clouds

WHAT IS IT?

Salesforce sells several clouds: Sales Cloud (sales), Service Cloud (support), Marketing Cloud (marketing), Experience Cloud (portals), Data Cloud (unified customer data), Commerce Cloud (e-commerce) and the Salesforce Platform used to build apps.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

Projects often connect Marketing Cloud to Sales or Service Cloud data. Knowing each cloud's job tells you where the data should come from.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Name the cloud that owns the customer's order history, support tickets and marketing consent in a typical company.
2. Decide which cloud is the system of record for each.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

A retailer keeps orders in Commerce Cloud, support cases in Service Cloud, and sends campaigns from Marketing Cloud.

COMMON ERRORS

Treating Marketing Cloud as the master customer database when the CRM should own it.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Where does Marketing Cloud fit in the Salesforce ecosystem?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a one-paragraph description of each cloud and its main data.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce: product overview

Module 2

2.2 Marketing Cloud Engagement and related products (naming and licensing)

WHAT IS IT?

> Marketing Cloud Engagement is the product for email, mobile, journeys and automation. Other Salesforce marketing products include Marketing Cloud Personalization, Marketing Cloud Intelligence and editions such as Growth and Advanced. Feature availability depends on the edition and the licence on your account.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Product names and editions change. Promising a feature that your edition lacks causes project failure.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Confirm the product name and edition on the Salesforce product pages.
2. Check the account's licensed features in Setup before designing a solution.
3. Record which features need a specific licence.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A proposal that needs real-time web personalisation must confirm the Personalization product is licensed, not assume Engagement includes it.

Licence and edition: Verify current editions and licences on Salesforce pages before you commit to a design.

COMMON ERRORS

Assuming every SFMC account has the same features.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you confirm what your account can do?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Make a table of five features and the product or edition that provides each, verified on official pages.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Marketing Cloud product pages

Module 3: SFMC Account Setup, Navigation and Administration

Level: Beginner. How an SFMC account is set up with business units, users, sender authentication and governance.

Module 3

3.1 Business units, the MID and account structure

WHAT IS IT?

> An SFMC account can hold an enterprise account with a parent business unit and child business units. Each business unit has its own MID (Marketing Cloud ID) and separate sending, data and assets, unless shared.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> The business unit design controls who sees which data and which sender domain is used. It is hard to change later, so design it first.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. List the brands or countries that need separate sending and data.
2. Create one child business unit per brand or country that needs isolation.
3. Decide which data extensions and assets are shared at parent level.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A group with two brands uses two child business units, each with its own sender profile and subscriber lists.

COMMON ERRORS

Creating too many business units, which splits data and makes reporting harder.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a business unit and why would you create one?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw a business unit design for a company with three brands and one shared footer library.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 3

3.2 Users, roles, sender authentication and delivery settings

WHAT IS IT?

> Users get roles and permission sets that decide what they can do in each business unit. Sender authentication (SPF, DKIM, and a branded tracking domain where used) proves to mailbox providers that a sender is legitimate. Sender and delivery profiles hold the From name, address and reply settings.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Poor authentication causes emails to land in spam and damages the sending reputation of the whole account.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create users with the least permissions they need.
2. Set up sender authentication with the DNS records provided by SFMC.
3. Create a sender profile and a delivery profile for each brand.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Adding the DKIM record in DNS and checking it in SFMC before the first campaign.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending from a domain you have not authenticated.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does sender authentication protect against?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a checklist of the DNS records and the SFMC settings needed before the first send.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: sender authentication

Module 4: Contact Management and Data Architecture

Level: Beginner. Contacts, subscribers and keys, and how the data is modelled so that every message reaches the right person.

Module 4

4.1 Subscribers, contacts and keys

WHAT IS IT?

> A subscriber is a person in Email Studio, identified by a subscriber key. A contact is a person in Contact Builder, identified by a contact key, and one contact can own several subscribers (for example, one per email address or business unit). Subscriber keys must be unique and stable.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Wrong keys are the most common cause of duplicate emails and lost unsubscribes.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Choose a stable identifier (customer ID) as the subscriber key.
2. Never use the email address as the key if the address can change.
3. Check that the contact key matches the subscriber key in your model.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Customer 10045 changes email address; the subscriber key stays 10045, so history and unsubscribes still apply.

COMMON ERRORS

Using email address as the key, then creating a new subscriber each time the address changes.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is the difference between a subscriber key and a contact key?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

List three possible subscriber key choices for a retailer and pick one with a reason.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

Module 4

4.2 Data architecture: keys, relationships and data views

WHAT IS IT?

> Relational data uses primary keys (unique identifiers) and foreign keys (links to other tables). In SFMC, data extensions are the tables; relationships are modelled with keys and in Contact Builder.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A clear model avoids joins that multiply rows and produce wrong counts.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define the primary key for each data extension.
2. Define the foreign key that links orders to customers.
3. Draw the relationship diagram before building.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Customers (CustomerID primary) and Orders (OrderID primary, CustomerID foreign).

COMMON ERRORS

Joining on a non-unique field, which multiplies rows.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a primary key and why must it be unique?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw the data model for customers, orders and products and label the keys.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 5: Data Extensions and Data Management

Level: Beginner. Data extensions: how they are created, imported, updated and kept clean.

Module 5

5.1 Creating and configuring data extensions

WHAT IS IT?

A data extension is an SFMC table. Types: standard, sendable (linked to a subscriber key and used for sends), non-sendable, and test. Each has fields with types, a primary key, nullable settings and retention settings.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

Choosing the right type and key decides whether the data can be used for sending and how long it stays.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create a data extension from the Email Studio or Contact Builder navigation.
2. Add fields with the right type (Text, Number, Date, Email, Phone, Boolean).
3. Set the primary key and make key fields non-nullable.
4. Set retention, for example delete all records after 365 days.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

A sendable data extension for customers with SubscriberKey as the send relationship field.

COMMON ERRORS

Choosing text for dates, so date filters fail.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a sendable data extension?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Create a customers data extension with five fields and a primary key in a sandbox account (or write the design if you have no account).

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 5

5.2 Importing, updating and cleaning data

WHAT IS IT?

> Data can be imported from CSV files, SFTP, Salesforce CRM, APIs and databases. Import options include overwrite, append, and update or insert on the primary key. Data quality checks catch duplicates, bad dates and missing keys.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Bad imports send emails to the wrong people. Validate before loading.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Prepare the CSV with a header row matching the field names.
2. Use the import activity with the update-or-insert option on the primary key.
3. Check row counts before and after the import.
4. Remove duplicates with a SQL query before the send.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Import 10,000 rows; the import reports 9,980 rows, so 20 rows had duplicate keys.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
-- Find duplicate keys before a send
SELECT SubscriberKey, COUNT(*) AS Copies
FROM Customers
GROUP BY SubscriberKey
HAVING COUNT(*) > 1;
```

COMMON ERRORS

Choosing overwrite when append was intended, and losing history.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you import daily customer updates without creating duplicates?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Import a sample CSV with planted duplicates and fix them with an import option and a SQL check.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: import data

Module 6: SQL for Salesforce Marketing Cloud

Level: Beginner to intermediate. SQL in SFMC: query activities, the supported syntax, aggregation, joins, data views and common audience queries.

Module 6

6.1 SQL fundamentals in SFMC

WHAT IS IT?

> SFMC SQL runs in Query Activities inside Automation Studio. It uses a T-SQL style syntax with some restrictions compared with SQL Server. Core clauses: SELECT, FROM, WHERE, GROUP BY, HAVING, ORDER BY.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Audiences, reports and suppression lists are almost always built with SQL in SFMC.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Write the query in the Query Activity.
2. Set a target data extension and an update option (overwrite or append).
3. Run the activity, then check the row count in the target.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Select active customers from the Customers data extension into an Audience data extension.

COMMON ERRORS

Writing a query that works in SQL Server but is not supported in SFMC. Always test in the Query Activity.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a Query Activity?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a query that selects customers in one city and counts them.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- SFMC SQL reference (Salesforce docs)

6.2 Aggregation, joins and CTEs

WHAT IS IT?

> Aggregates (COUNT, SUM, AVG, MIN, MAX) with GROUP BY summarise data. JOIN combines data extensions and system data views. Common table expressions (WITH) name steps. Check the official SQL restrictions for the exact features your account supports.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Joins and aggregates produce segments and reports; a wrong join silently changes audience size.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use INNER JOIN when both sides must match.
2. Use LEFT JOIN to keep all customers and show missing orders as NULL.
3. Count distinct customers, not rows, when a customer has many orders.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Customers with no order in 90 days: LEFT JOIN orders and keep rows where the order is NULL.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
-- Customers with no order in the last 90 days
SELECT c.SubscriberKey, c.EmailAddress
FROM Customers c
LEFT JOIN Orders o
  ON o.SubscriberKey = c.SubscriberKey
  AND o.OrderDate ⩾ DATEADD(day, -90, GETDATE())
WHERE o.OrderID IS NULL;
-- Line by line: LEFT JOIN keeps every customer; the date condition is inside the join so only
recent orders match;
-- WHERE o.OrderID IS NULL keeps customers with no matching recent order.
```

COMMON ERRORS

Counting rows where you need distinct customers.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain the difference between INNER JOIN and LEFT JOIN.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the 90-day inactivity query and explain each line.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- SFMC SQL reference (Salesforce docs)

Module 6

6.3 SFMC data views

WHAT IS IT?

> System data views hold sends, opens, clicks, bounces, unsubscribes, jobs, journey activity and SMS tracking. Examples: _Subscribers, _Sent, _Open, _Click, _Bounce, _Unsubscribe, _Job, _Journey, _JourneyActivity, _SMSMessageTracking, _Complaint, _BusinessUnitUnsubscribes. Each has its own keys and retention limit.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Engagement analysis and suppression depend on these views. Retention limits mean old data may be gone, so keep your own history.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Check the view's documentation for keys and retention.
2. Join on SubscriberKey and JobID where the view supports them.
3. Export long-term history to your own data extension.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Last-open date per subscriber: SELECT SubscriberKey, MAX(EventDate) FROM _Open GROUP BY SubscriberKey.

COMMON ERRORS

Assuming a data view keeps data forever.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is _Open used for and what limits apply?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

List the data views you would use for an engagement report and state each key and retention limit (verify on the docs).

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- SFMC data views (Salesforce docs)

Module 7: Email Studio

Level: Beginner to intermediate. Email Studio: sends, subscriber status, suppression and deliverability.

Module 7

7.1 Sends, classifications and subscriber status

WHAT IS IT?

> An email send is a definition with a data source, a send classification (commercial or transactional, depending on the law and consent), a sender profile and a delivery profile. Subscriber status includes active, unsubscribed, bounced and held.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Sending commercial email to unsubscribed people breaks the law in many places and damages reputation.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create the email, then the send definition.
2. Choose the send classification that matches the message (commercial needs consent and an unsubscribe link).
3. Use suppression lists for people who must not receive the message.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A password reset is transactional; a promotion is commercial with unsubscribe.

COMMON ERRORS

Using a commercial classification for transactional mail, or the reverse.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a send classification?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Classify five sample messages and explain each choice.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 7

7.2 Deliverability: SPF, DKIM, DMARC and bounce management

WHAT IS IT?

> SPF lists the servers allowed to send for a domain; DKIM signs messages; DMARC tells receivers what to do when checks fail. Bounces are hard (invalid address) or soft (temporary). Complaints and bounce rates affect reputation.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Good deliverability decides whether the message is seen at all.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Publish SPF and DKIM for the sending domain.
2. Add a DMARC policy starting with monitoring (p=none).
3. Remove hard-bounced addresses from the send.
4. Watch complaint rates after each send.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A hard bounce is suppressed automatically; a soft bounce is retried by the system.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending to old lists without removing bounces.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does DMARC do?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a deliverability checklist for a new sending domain.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Google: email sender guidelines

Module 8: Content Builder and Email Development

Level: Beginner to intermediate. Content Builder assets, responsive email design and dynamic content.

8.1 Content Builder assets and naming

WHAT IS IT?

> Content Builder stores emails, images, content blocks and templates in folders. Naming conventions make assets findable and safe to reuse.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Teams lose time looking for assets, and reused blocks change without warning if the naming and sharing are wrong.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create folders by brand, campaign type and year.
2. Name blocks with a prefix such as blk_footer_brandA.
3. Use shared content blocks for footers and legal text.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> blk_footer_brandA is used in 40 emails; one edit updates them all.

COMMON ERRORS

Editing a shared block without checking every email that uses it.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you organise Content Builder for three brands?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a folder and naming structure for two brands.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

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8.2 Responsive HTML email

WHAT IS IT?

Email HTML uses table-based layouts, inline CSS and media queries for mobile. Email clients have different support, so test in several clients.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

Most emails are opened on phones; a layout that breaks on mobile loses clicks.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use a single-column table layout with a maximum width of 600px.
2. Inline the key styles.
3. Use alt text on images and a text fallback for buttons.
4. Test on mobile and desktop clients.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

A two-column layout collapses to one column below 480px using a media query.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<body style="margin:0;background:#f4f4f7;font-family:Arial,sans-serif">
<table role="presentation" width="100%" cellpadding="0" cellspacing="0"><tr><td align="center">
  <table role="presentation" width="600" style="max-width:600px;background:#ffffff">
    <tr><td style="padding:24px;text-align:center;font-size:22px;font-
weight:bold;color:#2b1a66">Your new offers</td></tr>
    <tr><td style="padding:0 24px 24px;font-size:16px;color:#1d1b2e">
      Hi %%=ProperCase(AttributeValue("FirstName"))=%%, here are picks for you.
    </td></tr>
    <tr><td align="center" style="padding:0 24px 32px">
      <a href="https://example.com/offer" style="background:#5b37c9;color:#ffffff;padding:12px
22px;text-decoration:none;border-radius:6px">See offers</a>
    </td></tr>
  </table>
</td></tr></table>
</body>
</html>
```

COMMON ERRORS

Relying on CSS features that many clients ignore.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Why are email layouts built with tables?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Build a 600px responsive promotional email with a header, hero, two columns and a button.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Campaign Monitor: HTML email guide

Module 9: AMPscript Programming

Level: Intermediate. AMPscript: syntax, variables, personalisation, data extension lookups and debugging.

Module 9

9.1 Syntax, variables and personalisation

WHAT IS IT?

> AMPscript runs on the server inside %%[...]%% blocks and prints values with %%=...=%%. SET assigns a variable; AttributeValue reads a subscriber attribute; ProperCase formats names.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Almost every personalised SFMC email or CloudPage uses AMPscript.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Declare with VAR and assign with SET.
2. Print with %%= ... =%%.
3. Use AttributeValue for subscriber fields and provide a default in IIF or a check.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Hello %%=ProperCase(AttributeValue("FirstName"))=%%.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
%%[
  VAR @first, @greeting
  SET @first = AttributeValue("FirstName")
  IF Empty(@first) THEN
    SET @greeting = "there"
  ELSE
    SET @greeting = ProperCase(@first)
  ENDIF
]%%
Hello %%=v(@greeting)=%%,
// Line by line: VAR declares the variables; SET reads the subscriber's first name;
// IF/ELSE chooses the fallback when the field is empty; v() prints the variable.
```

COMMON ERRORS

Printing an empty first name, which shows 'Hello ,'.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does AttributeValue return if the attribute is missing?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a greeting that falls back to 'there' if FirstName is empty.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- AMPscript guide (Salesforce docs)

Module 9

9.2 Data extension lookups

WHAT IS IT?

> Lookup returns one value from a data extension by matching a field. LookupRows returns a set of rows. RowCount counts them. Always handle the case when nothing is found.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Lookups personalise messages from other data (orders, loyalty points) without a separate send.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use Lookup('DataExtension','ReturnField','MatchField',value).
2. Check RowCount on LookupRows before looping.
3. Use the subscriber key or email address as the match value.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Show the loyalty points for the subscriber's email.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
%%[
  VAR @tier
  SET @tier = Lookup("LoyaltyMembers", "Tier", "EmailAddress", emailaddr)
  IF Empty(@tier) THEN SET @tier = "Member" ENDIF
]%%
Your tier: %%=v(@tier)=%%
// Lookup matches EmailAddress to the subscriber email (emailaddr); if no row, @tier is empty and
the default is used.
```

COMMON ERRORS

Lookup on a field that is not unique and returns a random row.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain Lookup and LookupRows.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Show the loyalty tier with a Lookup and a default when no row exists.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- AMPscript guide (Salesforce docs)

Module 10: HTML, CSS and JavaScript for SFMC

Level: Beginner to intermediate. The web basics needed for emails and CloudPages, and where JavaScript is used in SFMC.

Module 10

10.1 HTML and CSS essentials for SFMC

WHAT IS IT?

> HTML gives structure (headings, paragraphs, links, images, tables, forms). CSS gives style (colours, spacing, fonts). In email, styles must be inlined and tables used for layout.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> You cannot fix a broken email or landing page without these basics.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Learn tags: h1, p, a, img, table, tr, td.
2. Learn selectors and properties.
3. Inline styles for email clients.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A link is an a tag with an href attribute.

COMMON ERRORS

Using div-based layouts in email.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is the difference between HTML and CSS?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Build a simple page with a heading, a paragraph and a link.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- MDN: HTML basics (official)

Module 10

10.2 JavaScript in CloudPages and forms

WHAT IS IT?

> JavaScript runs in the browser and can validate forms. Server-side JavaScript (SSJS) runs in SFMC for data work and is different from browser JavaScript. Keep secrets off the browser.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Forms and interactive pages need validation before data is saved.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Validate the email format before submit.
2. Show error messages next to fields.
3. Use SSJS only where the platform supports it and check the docs.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A registration form that checks the email format before posting.

COMMON ERRORS

Trusting browser validation alone; always validate on the server too.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Where would you run JavaScript in an SFMC project?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a browser check for an email field.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

Module 11: Journey Builder

Level: Intermediate. Journeys: entry sources, activities, splits, testing and troubleshooting.

11.1 Entry sources and activities

WHAT IS IT?

> A journey starts with an entry source (data extension, API event, Salesforce data, audience) and moves contacts through activities: email, SMS, push, wait, decision splits, engagement splits, random splits and update contact.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Journeys deliver the multi-step experiences customers expect, from welcome series to renewal reminders.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Choose an entry source that updates in near real time for triggered journeys.
2. Add an email activity and a wait activity.
3. Add a decision split on a data field (for example, plan type).

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Welcome journey: entry on sign-up, welcome email, wait 2 days, decision split on first login.

COMMON ERRORS

Entering contacts from a data extension that is refreshed once a week and expecting real-time triggers.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is an entry source and how do you choose one?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a three-step welcome journey on paper with entry, email, wait and a split.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Journey Builder documentation (Salesforce)

Module 11

11.2 Re-entry, exit criteria and testing

WHAT IS IT?

> Re-entry rules decide whether a contact can enter again. Exit criteria stop contacts who have completed or unsubscribed. Test with a test data extension before activating.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A wrong re-entry rule either floods a contact with messages or stops them from ever re-entering.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Set re-entry rules explicitly.
2. Add an exit on unsubscribe.
3. Test with a small test population, then review contact tracking.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Abandoned cart: re-entry allowed after 7 days, exit when the order completes.

COMMON ERRORS

Leaving re-entry at default without checking.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you troubleshoot a journey that does not accept contacts?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the test plan for an abandoned cart journey.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 12: Automation Studio

Level: Intermediate. Automations: SQL activities, file imports, scheduling and monitoring.

12.1 Activities and scheduling

WHAT IS IT?

> An automation is a sequence of activities such as SQL Query, Data Extract, File Transfer, Import File, Filter, Script, Verification and send activities, run on a schedule or on file arrival.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Automations prepare audiences and keep data current without manual work.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create the automation, add a SQL Query Activity, then a Data Extract if needed.
2. Set a schedule (daily at 02:00 for example).
3. Run once manually before scheduling.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Daily: import file, run audience query, filter, then send.

COMMON ERRORS

Scheduling before testing the SQL; failures then happen unattended.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you schedule a daily audience build?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Plan an automation with four activities and an order.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 12

12.2 Monitoring, errors and retries

WHAT IS IT?

> Automation status shows which activity failed. Verification activities check files or row counts before the next step. Failure notifications and logs help support teams.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Production failures need fast detection and a clear path back to working data.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Add a verification step after each import.
2. Set failure notifications to the owner.
3. Keep a rerun procedure.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A verification step stops the send if the file has fewer than 1,000 rows.

COMMON ERRORS

No row-count checks, so an empty file sends an empty campaign.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you troubleshoot an automation failure?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a runbook for a failed daily import.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

Module 13: Contact Builder and Data Designer

Level: Intermediate. Contact Builder: attribute groups, relationships and the contact model.

13.1 Attribute groups and relationships

WHAT IS IT?

> Attribute groups bring fields from several data extensions into one contact view. One-to-one and one-to-many relationships link them through contact keys.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A clear contact model is the base of multi-business-unit and Customer 360 designs.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create an attribute group from the contact's data extensions.
2. Link tables with the contact key.
3. Check that one contact returns one row per attribute group where expected.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Contact (1) to orders (many): an attribute group for orders shows the most recent order fields.

COMMON ERRORS

Joining one-to-many data and expecting one row per contact.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is an attribute group?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Model a customer with orders and loyalty tables in an attribute group design.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 13

13.2 Contact governance and deletion

WHAT IS IT?

> Contact deletion and retention decide how long personal data is kept. Governance records who owns the model and who may change it.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Retention is a legal requirement in many regions.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define retention per data extension.
2. Document contact deletion requests.
3. Review the contact model yearly.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A deletion request removes the contact and its linked records within the agreed time.

COMMON ERRORS

Keeping personal data forever.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you handle a deletion request in SFMC?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a deletion procedure for a privacy request.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 14: Mobile Studio and SMS Marketing

Level: Intermediate. MobileConnect for SMS and MobilePush for app notifications, with opt-in and compliance.

14.1 SMS and MobileConnect

WHAT IS IT?

> MobileConnect sends SMS. Keywords such as START and STOP handle opt-in and opt-out. Sender type (short code or long code) depends on the country and the account.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> SMS is strict on consent and frequency; mistakes lead to blocked messages and fines.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Record opt-in with a keyword or a form.
2. Send only to opted-in mobile numbers.
3. Include the opt-out instruction.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Text START to subscribe; reply STOP to unsubscribe, which is recorded automatically.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending SMS to numbers without consent.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you handle opt-out for SMS?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the opt-in and opt-out messages for a retail SMS programme.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: MobileConnect (verify current docs)

Module 14

14.2 MobilePush and compliance

WHAT IS IT?

> MobilePush sends notifications to mobile apps that register devices. Compliance covers consent, quiet hours, frequency and local messaging rules.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Notifications without consent or at night lose users.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Register devices with the app.
2. Target by segment.
3. Respect quiet hours and frequency caps.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A push at 10:00 local time for an opted-in user.

COMMON ERRORS

Ignoring the local rules for messages.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What checks apply before sending an SMS campaign?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a compliance checklist for SMS and push.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 15: CloudPages and Landing Page Development

Level: Intermediate. CloudPages: landing pages, forms, data capture and secure processing.

15.1 Building a registration page

WHAT IS IT?

> CloudPages are hosted pages built with HTML, CSS and AMPscript. A form posts data to a page that writes it to a data extension.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Lead capture and preference centres run on CloudPages.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Build the form with the required fields.
2. Read RequestParameter values on the page.
3. Write them to a data extension with UpsertDE.
4. Show a success or error message.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A newsletter sign-up writes the email to the Subscribers list.

COMMON ERRORS

Writing duplicate rows because the page never checks for an existing key.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you capture form data in CloudPages?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Build a newsletter sign-up page that writes to a data extension and handles duplicates.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- CloudPages documentation (Salesforce docs)

Module 15

15.2 Secure data capture and redirects

WHAT IS IT?

> Protect data by validating input, avoiding sensitive data in URLs and redirecting after success. Use RequestParameter and QueryParameter carefully.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Personal data in URLs ends up in logs and browser history.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Validate each field server-side.
2. Redirect after a successful post to avoid re-submits.
3. Do not put personal data in URLs.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> After submit, redirect to a thank-you page.

COMMON ERRORS

Accepting any input without checks.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you protect customer information on a form?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Add validation and a redirect to the registration page.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- AMPscript guide (Salesforce docs)

Module 16: Marketing Cloud Personalization

Level: Intermediate. Personalisation concepts and the current Marketing Cloud Personalization product, distinguished from legacy naming.

Module 16

16.1 Personalisation concepts and product naming

WHAT IS IT?

> Personalisation shows each visitor the content that fits their profile and behaviour. Marketing Cloud Personalization is the current Salesforce product for real-time web and app personalisation; older material may call it Interaction Studio.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Clear product names avoid buying or building the wrong capability.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Confirm the product and its licence.
2. Map the data sources the product needs.
3. Define one measurable goal per experience.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A product page shows recommended items based on past browsing.

COMMON ERRORS

Using old Interaction Studio material for current features without checking.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How does personalisation differ from segmentation?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a one-page personalisation brief with one goal and its data sources.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce product pages (verify current naming)

Module 17: Marketing Cloud Intelligence and Analytics

Level: Intermediate. Campaign analytics, cross-channel reporting and the Intelligence product.

Module 17

17.1 Campaign analytics and attribution

WHAT IS IT?

> Analytics measure open, click, conversion and revenue by campaign and channel. Attribution assigns credit to channels. Intelligence connects data from many sources for cross-channel reporting.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Budget decisions depend on which channels create revenue.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define the revenue and conversion events.
2. Map campaign IDs consistently.
3. Build a dashboard with one page per question.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Email revenue per campaign: sum of orders attributed to each send within seven days.

COMMON ERRORS

Comparing channels with different attribution windows.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you measure campaign ROI?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Calculate ROI for three campaigns with stated assumptions.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Marketing Cloud Intelligence docs (verify current product)

Module 18: SFMC APIs and Integrations

Level: Advanced. REST and SOAP APIs, installed packages, OAuth, and integration patterns with Salesforce and other systems.

18.1 REST authentication with an installed package

WHAT IS IT?

> An installed package in SFMC gives an app a client ID and secret. The app requests an access token from the account's auth endpoint, then calls REST endpoints with the token. Token requests use your account subdomain.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Every integration starts with authentication; mistakes cause 401 errors and leaked credentials.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create an installed package with the required API permissions.
2. Copy the client ID, secret and subdomain (store them in a secrets manager).
3. Request a token and call one endpoint.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> POST to the token endpoint, then GET a data extension list with the bearer token.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
# Token request (replace the subdomain and credentials; never commit them)
curl -X POST "https://YOUR_SUBDOMAIN.auth.marketingcloudapis.com/v2/token" \
  -H "Content-Type: application/json" \
  -d '{"grant_type":"client_credentials","client_id":"YOUR_ID","client_secret":"YOUR_SECRET"}'
# The response contains access_token. Use it as: Authorization: Bearer <access_token>
```

COMMON ERRORS

Putting the client secret in front-end code.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain how OAuth works in an SFMC integration.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Authenticate with a sandbox account and list data extensions with Postman.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Marketing Cloud REST and SOAP API docs

Module 18

18.2 REST versus SOAP and common patterns

WHAT IS IT?

> REST uses JSON over HTTP and is the recommended approach for new work. SOAP uses XML and WSDL and remains available for some legacy operations. Patterns: create triggered sends, upsert contacts, read tracking data, manage assets.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Choosing the right API avoids rework; REST is simpler to test.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use REST for new integrations.
2. Check the docs for each operation's rate limits.
3. Log every request and response status.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Triggered send: POST with the subscriber, the email definition and personalisation attributes.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending bulk data one record at a time instead of using batch endpoints.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

REST versus SOAP: which would you use and why?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Describe a triggered-send integration with request, response and error handling.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

Module 19: Salesforce Data Cloud and Marketing Cloud Integration

Level: Advanced. Data Cloud concepts and how unified profiles reach Marketing Cloud for activation.

Module 19

19.1 Data Cloud concepts

WHAT IS IT?

> Data Cloud ingests data from many sources, resolves identities into unified profiles, and makes segments and calculated insights available for activation, including to Marketing Cloud. Naming and licensing change; check current Salesforce documentation.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Enterprise Customer 360 projects depend on unified profiles.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Map sources to data streams.
2. Define identity resolution rules.
3. Build a segment and activate it to Marketing Cloud.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Web events and CRM records unified into one profile; the segment 'recent buyers' activates to a journey.

COMMON ERRORS

Assuming Data Cloud is included with Marketing Cloud Engagement.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is identity resolution?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw the data flow from three sources to one activated segment.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Data Cloud documentation (verify)

Module 20: Advanced Marketing Automation and Personalisation

Level: Advanced. Event-driven and lifecycle automation, advanced segmentation and optimisation.

Module 20

20.1 Lifecycle automation and optimisation

WHAT IS IT?

> Lifecycle automation runs journeys on events (sign-up, purchase, lapse). Optimisation tests variants, frequency and send times, measuring the results with control groups.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Automated lifecycle programmes compound revenue and retention.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define the lifecycle events.
2. Create a control group to measure lift.
3. Test one variable at a time.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Win-back journey with a 10% holdout to measure incremental revenue.

COMMON ERRORS

Declaring success without a control group.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you measure a journey's incremental impact?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a win-back test with a holdout and a success metric.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 21: SFMC Security, Privacy and Deliverability

Level: Advanced. Access control, consent, deliverability and compliance with data protection laws.

Module 21

21.1 Security and access

WHAT IS IT?

> Access control uses roles, permission sets and business-unit access. API credentials need least privilege and rotation. Audit trails record changes.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Breaches usually come from over-broad access or leaked credentials.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Review roles every quarter.
2. Rotate API secrets.
3. Keep audit logs on.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A campaign manager cannot export the full customer table.

COMMON ERRORS

Sharing one admin login between people.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you control access in an SFMC account?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write an access review checklist.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 21

21.2 Privacy and compliance

WHAT IS IT?

> GDPR (EU) and India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act set rules for consent, minimisation, access and deletion. CAN-SPAM (US) and CASL (Canada) set email rules. Check the rules that apply to each audience.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Non-compliance leads to fines and blocked sends.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Record consent and its source.
2. Honour unsubscribes immediately.
3. Keep data only as long as needed.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A consent flag in the contact model controls which journeys a person may enter.

COMMON ERRORS

Treating consent as one checkbox for every channel.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do GDPR and DPDP affect marketing data?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a consent model for email and SMS.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- GDPR text (official EU)
- MeitY: DPDP framework (official)

Module 22: SFMC Testing, Troubleshooting and Performance

Level: Advanced. Testing campaigns and integrations, troubleshooting failures and tuning performance.

Module 22

22.1 Testing and troubleshooting

WHAT IS IT?

> Test email previews, personalisation, links, journeys with test contacts, automations on sample data, SQL on small populations and APIs with sandbox calls. Troubleshooting follows the error, the logs and recent changes.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Most production incidents are preventable with a test plan.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Send tests to seed addresses.
2. Check each personalisation with a missing value.
3. Run SQL on a sample before a full run.
4. Keep a runbook.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A seed-list test shows a broken personalisation before the real send.

COMMON ERRORS

Testing only with one perfect record.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you investigate a failed email send?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Create a test plan for a welcome email and journey.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 23: SFMC Architecture and Enterprise Implementation

Level: Advanced. Architecture decisions for multi-business-unit programmes and how to document them.

Module 23

23.1 Multi-business-unit architecture

WHAT IS IT?

> Decide what is shared at parent level (footers, compliance text, reference data) and what is isolated per business unit (sender, subscribers, data). Document each decision.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Architecture choices decide governance, cost and how easily brands can change.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Write requirements (functional and non-functional).
2. Draw the business unit and data diagram.
3. Record decisions as ADRs.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Shared reference data at parent; brand subscribers isolated in child business units.

COMMON ERRORS

Sharing subscriber data across brands without a legal basis.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Design a multi-business-unit SFMC solution.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a one-page architecture for two brands with one shared footer library.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- C4 model (diagrams)

Module 24: AI in Marketing Cloud and Intelligent Automation

Level: Advanced. AI features in marketing automation, with product names and licences checked on official pages, and AI integration with APIs.

Module 24

24.1 AI for campaigns and analytics

WHAT IS IT?

> AI can draft subject lines and copy, suggest segments, predict churn and recommend next actions. Salesforce AI capabilities are offered under specific product and licence names; verify before promising them.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> AI speeds up content work but needs human approval and tested outputs.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use AI to draft, a human to approve.
2. Test generated copy for compliance and brand rules.
3. Measure lift against the control group.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> AI drafts three subject lines; the team tests two with a 10% split.

COMMON ERRORS

Publishing AI copy without review.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you use AI safely in a campaign workflow?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design an AI copy workflow with human approval steps.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce AI overview (verify)

Module 24

24.2 Integrating an external AI model

WHAT IS IT?

> An integration sends campaign data to an AI model API and writes the result back to a data extension. Keep personal data minimal and never send secrets to a model.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> External models are useful when a feature is not in the SFMC licence.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Send only the fields the model needs.
2. Store the output in a review table.
3. Log model version and cost.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A monthly churn score is written to a data extension, then used in a journey split.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending full customer records to a third-party model.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you add an AI score to a journey safely?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design the data flow for a churn-score integration with privacy controls.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Anthropic: API docs
- OpenAI: API docs

Module 25: Practical Labs and Real-World Scenarios

Level: All levels. Twenty step-by-step labs. Some need a provisioned SFMC account; others are simulated or can be done on paper.

Module 25

25.1 How to use the labs

WHAT IS IT?

> Each lab lists the objective, scenario, prerequisites, tools, dataset, steps, code, expected output, validation, common errors and assessment. Labs marked 'account' need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account; labs marked 'simulated' can be done with sample files and paper.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Practice on real data builds the skill employers test for.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Check the lab's requirement tag first.
2. Work in a sandbox or test business unit.
3. Keep a log of errors and fixes.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Lab 4: import and clean customer records (account required).

COMMON ERRORS

Practising in production.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you practise SFMC without a paid account?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Pick one simulated lab and complete it on sample files.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 26: Capstone Projects and Portfolio

Level: Advanced. Eight capstone projects with requirements, architecture, code, testing and demo evidence.

Module 26

26.1 Portfolio standard

WHAT IS IT?

> Each project includes business problem, users, scope, requirements, architecture, data model, data flow, steps, SQL and AMPscript code, testing, evidence, KPIs, impact, limitations, future work, documentation and a demo video.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A portfolio with evidence gets interviews; a list of tools does not.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Write the business problem first.
2. Build and test each part.
3. Record a 3-minute demo.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Project 3: abandoned cart automation with SQL segments and a multi-channel follow-up.

COMMON ERRORS

Showing screenshots with no explanation.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does a strong SFMC portfolio project include?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Choose one of the eight projects and write its requirements.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 27: SFMC Interview Preparation and Career Readiness

Level: All levels. Technical, scenario and behavioural interviews for SFMC roles, with a question bank and practice plan.

Module 27

27.1 Interview readiness

WHAT IS IT?

> Interviews test SQL, AMPscript, journeys, automations, APIs, architecture and troubleshooting. Practise by explaining your own projects with results.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Hiring managers look for evidence of production work and clear reasoning.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Practise 20 SQL questions and 10 AMPscript exercises.
2. Prepare two project stories with results.
3. Do two mock interviews a week.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Scenario: a high bounce rate. Investigate by list source, hard versus soft bounce, domain, timing and sender reputation.

COMMON ERRORS

Answering without a method.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

A campaign has a high bounce rate. How do you investigate?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Answer the eight scenario questions out loud and record yourself.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Interview bank: see the Interview Preparation Handbook

Module 28: Certification Preparation and Learning Roadmap

Level: All levels. How to prepare for Salesforce certifications and a realistic 12-month plan. Certification names must be checked on Trailhead before you register.

Module 28

28.1 Certifications and the roadmap

WHAT IS IT?

> Salesforce certifications change over time. Check the official Trailhead credentials catalogue for active names, prerequisites, exam objectives and weighting. The roadmap in this academy gives a 12-month study plan.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A current, recognised certification helps screening, but experience matters more.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Open the official credentials list on Trailhead and note active names.
2. Read the exam guide for the one you choose.
3. Follow the 12-month roadmap.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Plan: months 1 to 3 fundamentals; months 4 to 8 applied labs; months 9 to 12 projects and exam.

COMMON ERRORS

Registering before the exam guide is read.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you prepare for an SFMC certification?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write your own 12-month plan using the template.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Trailhead credentials (official)

Practical labs (Module 25)

Each lab lists the objective, scenario, prerequisites, tools, dataset, steps, code, expected output, validation, common errors and assessment in the full lab workbook (next batch). Use this list to plan.

Lab	Title	Requirement
Lab 1	Create a basic SFMC account and understand the environment	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 2	Design an enterprise business unit structure	Simulated or paper practice
Lab 3	Create a customer data extension	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 4	Import and clean customer records	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 5	Write SQL segmentation queries	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 6	Create an email template	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 7	Build a personalised email using AMPscript	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 8	Create a dynamic content email	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 9	Build a welcome journey	Needs a provisioned SFMC account

Lab 10	Create an abandoned cart journey	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 11	Build a customer retention automation	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 12	Create a scheduled SQL automation	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 13	Build a CloudPage registration form	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 14	Integrate SFMC using REST APIs	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 15	Create an API-triggered email	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 16	Build an SMS customer notification	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 17	Create a marketing performance dashboard	Simulated or paper practice
Lab 18	Integrate Salesforce CRM data	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 19	Design a Customer 360 activation workflow	Simulated or paper practice
Lab 20	Develop an AI-assisted marketing automation workflow	Simulated or paper practice

SkillNavora

MODULE 1 HANDBOOK

Module 1: CRM and Digital Marketing Fundamentals

4 sections, 40 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
Edition: November 2026. Practice labs marked "account" need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account. Other labs use sample files or paper.

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Module 1: CRM and Digital Marketing Fundamentals

Level: Beginner. What CRM and digital marketing are, the customer lifecycle, channels and the metrics every campaign is judged on.

Contents

1. 1.1 CRM Fundamentals
2. 1.2 Digital Marketing Fundamentals
3. 1.3 Marketing Strategy
4. 1.4 Marketing Analytics

Detailed lessons

Module 1

1.1 CRM and the customer lifecycle

WHAT IS IT?

> A CRM (customer relationship management) system stores customers, their interactions and their history. The lifecycle runs from first awareness to acquisition, onboarding, engagement, retention and re-engagement.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Marketing automation only works when the customer data and lifecycle stage are right. Most campaign mistakes come from wrong audiences, not wrong emails.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. List the lifecycle stages for your product (for example: visitor, lead, customer, active, lapsed).
2. For each stage, write one message and one goal.
3. Map each stage to the data you need (sign-up date, last purchase, last open).

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A bank: a visitor who applies for a card moves to lead; approval makes them a customer; no transaction for 90 days starts a re-engagement journey.

COMMON ERRORS

Mixing up lead and customer, so a paying customer gets an acquisition offer.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain the customer lifecycle and one message for each stage.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw the lifecycle for an online course business with five stages and the data field that marks each stage.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 1

1.2 Channels and marketing metrics

WHAT IS IT?

> Digital channels include email, SMS, push notifications, web and social media, plus paid advertising. Key metrics: open rate, click-through rate, click-to-open rate, conversion rate, bounce rate, unsubscribe rate and revenue per send.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Metrics show whether a campaign works and where to fix it. Open rates are affected by Apple Mail privacy features, so click-based metrics are often more reliable.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Calculate open rate as unique opens divided by delivered emails.
2. Calculate click-through rate as unique clicks divided by delivered emails.
3. Calculate click-to-open rate as unique clicks divided by unique opens.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> 1,000 delivered, 250 unique opens, 40 unique clicks: open rate 25%, CTR 4%, CTOR 16%.

COMMON ERRORS

Comparing open rates between campaigns that used different send times or audiences.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is the difference between CTR and CTOR?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Calculate the metrics for three sample campaigns and say which one to repeat and why.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Trailhead: marketing basics

1.1 CRM Fundamentals: every topic explained

What is Customer Relationship Management?. CRM is software and practice for managing every interaction with customers and prospects: who they are, what they bought, and every contact with sales, service and marketing.

CRM architecture. A CRM has a database of accounts, contacts and leads, business objects (opportunities, cases, orders), workflows and reports, usually reached through a web app and APIs.

CRM versus marketing automation. CRM is the system of record for customer relationships; marketing automation sends and tracks campaigns. Marketing tools read CRM data and write engagement back.

Customer lifecycle. The stages a customer moves through: awareness, consideration, purchase, onboarding, active use, loyalty, lapse and win-back. Each stage needs a different message.

Customer data management. Keeping customer data accurate, de-duplicated, consented and up to date, with clear owners and rules for creation and change.

Lead and contact management. A lead is an unqualified prospect; a contact is a known person linked to an account. Leads are qualified and converted into contacts and opportunities.

Customer segmentation. Grouping customers by shared traits (industry, value, behaviour, lifecycle stage) so each group gets relevant messages.

Customer engagement. The level of two-way interaction a customer has with the brand: opens, clicks, visits, purchases, replies and support contact.

Customer retention. Keeping existing customers buying or subscribing. It is usually cheaper than acquiring new customers and is a core marketing goal.

Customer lifetime value. The expected profit from a customer over the whole relationship. Simple form: average order value × purchases per year × years retained × margin.

CRM reporting. Standard CRM reports and dashboards for pipeline, conversion, campaign influence and customer health, used by sales and marketing leaders.

1.2 Digital Marketing Fundamentals: every topic explained

Digital marketing ecosystem. All the online channels a brand uses (email, SMS, push, web, social, search, display, apps) and the tools that connect them.

Email marketing. Permission-based messages sent to a list. It has a strong return because the audience is owned, but depends on consent and deliverability.

SMS marketing. Short text messages to mobile numbers with consent. High open rates; strict rules on opt-in, opt-out, timing and frequency.

Push notifications. Notifications sent to users of a mobile app who allowed them. Used for timely alerts, offers and reminders.

Web marketing. The website and landing pages: content, forms, personalisation and tracking that turn visits into leads and sales.

Social media marketing. Organic posts and community building on social platforms, plus social listening and customer service.

Paid advertising. Paid search, social and display ads bought by impression or click, targeted by audience and keywords.

Marketing automation. Software that sends the right message at the right time automatically based on rules, events and data, such as welcome series and cart reminders.

Omnichannel marketing. A consistent customer experience across channels, where each channel knows the customer's context and history.

1.3 Marketing Strategy: every topic explained

Customer acquisition. Attracting new customers through ads, content, referrals and lead capture, then converting them to first purchase.

Customer onboarding. Helping new customers get value fast with a welcome series, setup steps and first-use help.

Customer engagement. Keeping customers active with useful content, offers and reminders based on their behaviour.

Customer retention. Programmes that reduce churn: loyalty, service follow-ups, renewal reminders and win-back offers.

Re-engagement campaigns. Campaigns for people who stopped opening or buying, with a clear offer and a sunset rule if they still do not respond.

Cross-selling. Offering a related product to an existing customer, such as a phone case after a phone purchase.

Upselling. Offering a higher-value version or upgrade, such as a premium plan.

Customer journey mapping. Drawing each step a customer takes, their goals and the touchpoints, to find where messages help.

Marketing funnels. The stages from awareness to purchase (and beyond), with conversion rates between stages to show where people drop off.

Campaign planning. Defining the goal, audience, message, channels, timing, budget and measures for a campaign before building it.

1.4 Marketing Analytics: every topic explained

Open rate. Unique opens divided by delivered emails. Inflated by privacy features that pre-load images, so use it with care.

Click-through rate. Unique clicks divided by delivered emails: a better signal of real interest.

Click-to-open rate. Unique clicks divided by unique opens: how well the content worked for people who opened.

Conversion rate. Share of recipients who completed the goal (purchase, sign-up) after the message.

Bounce rate. Share of emails that could not be delivered. Hard bounces are permanent; soft bounces are temporary.

Unsubscribe rate. Share of recipients who unsubscribed after a send. A rising rate warns of poor targeting or frequency.

Deliverability. Whether email reaches the inbox (not spam). Depends on authentication, reputation, list quality and content.

Revenue attribution. Giving revenue credit to the messages and channels that influenced a sale (first touch, last touch, multi-touch).

Campaign ROI. Return on investment: (revenue − cost) ÷ cost for the campaign, with stated assumptions.

Customer engagement metrics. Measures such as active rate, frequency of interaction and recency that show how engaged customers are over time.

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MODULE 2 HANDBOOK

Module 2: Salesforce Ecosystem and Marketing Cloud Introduction

5 sections, 49 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
Edition: November 2026. Practice labs marked "account" need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account. Other labs use sample files or paper.

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Module 2: Salesforce Ecosystem and Marketing Cloud Introduction

Level: Beginner. Where Marketing Cloud fits among the Salesforce clouds, and how the Engagement product, its business units and its studios are organised.

Contents

1. 2.1 Salesforce Fundamentals
2. 2.2 Marketing Cloud Fundamentals
3. 2.3 SFMC Architecture
4. 2.4 Marketing Cloud Components
5. 2.5 Understanding the SFMC Interface

Detailed lessons

Module 2

2.1 The Salesforce clouds

WHAT IS IT?

> Salesforce sells several clouds: Sales Cloud (sales), Service Cloud (support), Marketing Cloud (marketing), Experience Cloud (portals), Data Cloud (unified customer data), Commerce Cloud (e-commerce) and the Salesforce Platform used to build apps.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Projects often connect Marketing Cloud to Sales or Service Cloud data. Knowing each cloud's job tells you where the data should come from.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Name the cloud that owns the customer's order history, support tickets and marketing consent in a typical company.
2. Decide which cloud is the system of record for each.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A retailer keeps orders in Commerce Cloud, support cases in Service Cloud, and sends campaigns from Marketing Cloud.

COMMON ERRORS

Treating Marketing Cloud as the master customer database when the CRM should own it.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Where does Marketing Cloud fit in the Salesforce ecosystem?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a one-paragraph description of each cloud and its main data.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce: product overview

Module 2

2.2 Marketing Cloud Engagement and related products (naming and licensing)

WHAT IS IT?

> Marketing Cloud Engagement is the product for email, mobile, journeys and automation. Other Salesforce marketing products include Marketing Cloud Personalization, Marketing Cloud Intelligence and editions such as Growth and Advanced. Feature availability depends on the edition and the licence on your account.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Product names and editions change. Promising a feature that your edition lacks causes project failure.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Confirm the product name and edition on the Salesforce product pages.
2. Check the account's licensed features in Setup before designing a solution.
3. Record which features need a specific licence.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A proposal that needs real-time web personalisation must confirm the Personalization product is licensed, not assume Engagement includes it.

Licence and edition: Verify current editions and licences on Salesforce pages before you commit to a design.

COMMON ERRORS

Assuming every SFMC account has the same features.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you confirm what your account can do?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Make a table of five features and the product or edition that provides each, verified on official pages.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Marketing Cloud product pages

2.1 Salesforce Fundamentals: every topic explained

What is Salesforce?. Salesforce is a cloud CRM company whose products manage sales, service, marketing, commerce and customer data.

Salesforce ecosystem. The products, platform, partner apps (AppExchange), community and consultants around Salesforce.

CRM architecture. Salesforce uses a multi-tenant cloud with a metadata-driven platform: objects, fields, automation and security model, used through apps and APIs.

Salesforce clouds. The product families: Sales, Service, Marketing, Experience, Commerce, Data Cloud and more, each licensed separately.

Sales Cloud. Manages leads, accounts, contacts, opportunities and forecasts for sales teams.

Service Cloud. Manages cases, knowledge and service channels for support teams.

Marketing Cloud. Salesforce's marketing products, including Marketing Cloud Engagement for email, mobile, journeys and automation.

Experience Cloud. Builds portals and sites for customers, partners and communities on Salesforce data.

Data Cloud. Unifies customer data from many sources into profiles for segmentation, insights and activation.

Commerce Cloud. Runs B2C and B2B e-commerce storefronts.

Salesforce Platform. The underlying platform for building custom objects, apps, automation and integrations.

2.2 Marketing Cloud Fundamentals: every topic explained

What is Salesforce Marketing Cloud?. A Salesforce family of products for digital marketing. Developers and administrators usually mean Marketing Cloud Engagement when they say SFMC.

Marketing Cloud Engagement. The core product for email, mobile, Journey Builder, Automation Studio, Contact Builder and CloudPages.

Marketing Cloud Growth. A Salesforce marketing edition built on the core Salesforce platform and Data Cloud, aimed at simpler marketing needs. Check current scope on Salesforce's pages.

Marketing Cloud Advanced. A higher Salesforce marketing edition with more advanced capabilities, also built on the platform. Check current scope and licensing.

Marketing Cloud Personalization. The real-time web and app personalisation product, formerly called Interaction Studio.

Marketing Cloud Intelligence. Cross-channel marketing analytics and reporting, formerly known as Datorama.

Marketing Cloud architecture. Engagement is a separate multi-tenant system with its own accounts, business units, data extensions and APIs, connected to Salesforce through connectors.

Business units. Separate units inside an Engagement account, each with its own sending settings, users, data and assets.

Enterprise accounts. The top-level account type that holds a parent business unit and its child business units.

MID and account structure. The MID (member ID) is the numeric ID of each business unit and is used in APIs, support and configuration.

2.3 SFMC Architecture: every topic explained

Tenant architecture. Engagement runs on Salesforce-managed infrastructure (stacks); each customer account is a tenant with its own data.

Enterprise and child business units. The parent (enterprise) business unit can share data and assets down to child business units.

Account structure. How the enterprise, business units, users and roles are arranged.

Subscriber model. The Email Studio model of subscribers, lists and statuses keyed by subscriber key.

Contact model. The Contact Builder model that unifies a person across channels by contact key.

Data model. Data extensions, data views and relationships that hold the customer, transaction and engagement data.

Shared data extensions. Data extensions created in the shared folder of the parent business unit and made available to child units.

Roles and permissions. Roles group permissions; users get roles per business unit to control what they can see and do.

Multi-business-unit implementation. Designs where several brands or countries run in separate business units with shared parts, governed centrally.

2.4 Marketing Cloud Components: every topic explained

Email Studio. Creates, sends and tracks email; manages subscribers, lists and sends.

Content Builder. The content library for emails, templates, blocks and images across channels.

Journey Builder. Builds multi-step, multi-channel customer journeys triggered by events or data.

Automation Studio. Schedules and runs data work: SQL queries, imports, exports, file transfers and sends.

Contact Builder. Manages contacts, data extensions, relationships (Data Designer) and imports.

Mobile Studio. SMS (MobileConnect) and app push (MobilePush) messaging.

CloudPages. Hosted landing pages, forms and microsites using HTML and AMPscript.

Analytics. Reports and analytics such as Analytics Builder and tracking reports.

Intelligence. Marketing Cloud Intelligence for cross-channel reporting (separate licence).

2.5 Understanding the SFMC Interface: every topic explained

Login and navigation. Log in with your username and multi-factor authentication, then choose the business unit to work in.

Application switcher. The menu that switches between studios and builders.

Marketing Cloud dashboard. The landing view after login, with shortcuts and recent items.

Setup. Setup holds account, user, security and channel settings.

Administration. Administrative tasks: users, roles, business units, sender profiles and account settings.

Email Studio navigation. Email Studio menus: Content, Subscribers, Interactions, Tracking, Admin.

Automation Studio navigation. Automation Studio: overview of automations, activities and run history.

Journey Builder navigation. Journey Builder: journeys list, canvas, entry sources and activity panel.

Content Builder navigation. Content Builder: folders, assets, blocks and templates.

Contact Builder navigation. Contact Builder: All Contacts, Data Designer, Data Extensions and Imports.

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MODULE 3 HANDBOOK

Module 3: SFMC Account Setup, Navigation and Administration

4 sections, 31 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
Edition: November 2026. Practice labs marked "account" need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account. Other labs use sample files or paper.

Module 3: SFMC Account Setup, Navigation and Administration

Level: Beginner. How an SFMC account is set up with business units, users, sender authentication and governance.

Contents

1. 3.1 Account Setup
2. 3.2 User Administration
3. 3.3 Setup and Configuration
4. 3.4 Administration and Governance

Detailed lessons

Module 3

3.1 Business units, the MID and account structure

WHAT IS IT?

> An SFMC account can hold an enterprise account with a parent business unit and child business units. Each business unit has its own MID (Marketing Cloud ID) and separate sending, data and assets, unless shared.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> The business unit design controls who sees which data and which sender domain is used. It is hard to change later, so design it first.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. List the brands or countries that need separate sending and data.
2. Create one child business unit per brand or country that needs isolation.
3. Decide which data extensions and assets are shared at parent level.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A group with two brands uses two child business units, each with its own sender profile and subscriber lists.

COMMON ERRORS

Creating too many business units, which splits data and makes reporting harder.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a business unit and why would you create one?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw a business unit design for a company with three brands and one shared footer library.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 3

3.2 Users, roles, sender authentication and delivery settings

WHAT IS IT?

> Users get roles and permission sets that decide what they can do in each business unit. Sender authentication (SPF, DKIM, and a branded tracking domain where used) proves to mailbox providers that a sender is legitimate. Sender and delivery profiles hold the From name, address and reply settings.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Poor authentication causes emails to land in spam and damages the sending reputation of the whole account.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create users with the least permissions they need.
2. Set up sender authentication with the DNS records provided by SFMC.
3. Create a sender profile and a delivery profile for each brand.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Adding the DKIM record in DNS and checking it in SFMC before the first campaign.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending from a domain you have not authenticated.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does sender authentication protect against?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a checklist of the DNS records and the SFMC settings needed before the first send.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: sender authentication

3.1 Account Setup: every topic explained

SFMC account provisioning. Salesforce sets up the account and stack when the licence is bought; admins then configure it.

Enterprise account. The top-level account that contains the parent business unit.

Business units. Separate working units under the enterprise account.

MID. Each business unit's numeric member ID, used in APIs and support.

Parent and child business units. The parent holds shared items; children inherit what is shared and keep their own data.

Account configuration. Settings such as time zone, locale, sender defaults and security.

Account settings. Account-wide options set in Setup, including password and session policies.

3.2 User Administration: every topic explained

User creation. Admins create users with username, email, role and business unit access.

User management. Updating, deactivating and auditing users as people join and leave.

Roles. Predefined or custom groups of permissions (for example, Marketing Cloud Administrator, Content Editor).

Permissions. Fine-grained rights such as create, edit, delete, send and export.

Permission sets. Bundles of permissions assigned in addition to roles where the account supports them.

User access. Which business units and tools each user can open.

Multi-factor authentication. A second check (app or code) at login. Required for many Salesforce products.

Login security. Policies for passwords, session timeouts, IP allow-lists and login monitoring.

3.3 Setup and Configuration: every topic explained

Sender authentication. Proves the sender owns the domain using DNS records so mailbox providers trust the mail.

Sender profiles. From name and address used on sends.

Delivery profiles. Delivery settings: IP address, header and footer used on sends.

Send classifications. Combines sender profile, delivery profile and commercial or transactional type for a send.

Reply mail management. Handles replies to sends: forward, auto-reply, or process unsubscribes from replies.

Domain configuration. Configures the sending and tracking domains in DNS.

Private domains. A domain you own and authenticate for sending, instead of a shared domain.

Dedicated IP concepts. A dedicated IP is used only by your account; reputation then depends only on your sending.

Account-level settings. Global settings such as default sender, tracking options and data retention defaults.

3.4 Administration and Governance: every topic explained

Business unit governance. Rules for who creates business units, what is shared, and how changes are approved.

Folder structures. A consistent folder tree for content, data extensions and automations.

Naming conventions. Name patterns such as DE_Customers_Master or EM_Welcome_01 that make assets findable.

Access management. Regular review of users and roles; remove access that is no longer needed.

Asset management. Managing asset creation, reuse, versioning and archiving.

Audit considerations. Keep a record of changes, sends and access for audits.

Configuration management. Documenting settings and changes so environments can be rebuilt or compared.

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MODULE 4 HANDBOOK

Module 4: Contact Management and Data Architecture

4 sections, 33 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 4: Contact Management and Data Architecture

Level: Beginner. Contacts, subscribers and keys, and how the data is modelled so that every message reaches the right person.

Contents

1. 4.1 Contact Fundamentals
2. 4.2 Contact Model
3. 4.3 SFMC Data Architecture
4. 4.4 Data Modelling

Detailed lessons

Module 4

4.1 Subscribers, contacts and keys

WHAT IS IT?

> A subscriber is a person in Email Studio, identified by a subscriber key. A contact is a person in Contact Builder, identified by a contact key, and one contact can own several subscribers (for example, one per email address or business unit). Subscriber keys must be unique and stable.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Wrong keys are the most common cause of duplicate emails and lost unsubscribes.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Choose a stable identifier (customer ID) as the subscriber key.
2. Never use the email address as the key if the address can change.
3. Check that the contact key matches the subscriber key in your model.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Customer 10045 changes email address; the subscriber key stays 10045, so history and unsubscribes still apply.

COMMON ERRORS

Using email address as the key, then creating a new subscriber each time the address changes.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is the difference between a subscriber key and a contact key?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

List three possible subscriber key choices for a retailer and pick one with a reason.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

Module 4

4.2 Data architecture: keys, relationships and data views

WHAT IS IT?

> Relational data uses primary keys (unique identifiers) and foreign keys (links to other tables). In SFMC, data extensions are the tables; relationships are modelled with keys and in Contact Builder.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A clear model avoids joins that multiply rows and produce wrong counts.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define the primary key for each data extension.
2. Define the foreign key that links orders to customers.
3. Draw the relationship diagram before building.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Customers (CustomerID primary) and Orders (OrderID primary, CustomerID foreign).

COMMON ERRORS

Joining on a non-unique field, which multiplies rows.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a primary key and why must it be unique?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw the data model for customers, orders and products and label the keys.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

4.1 Contact Fundamentals: every topic explained

Contacts. People known to Marketing Cloud across channels, managed in Contact Builder.

Subscribers. People in Email Studio who can receive email, with a status per list.

Leads. Prospects not yet customers, often synchronised from Sales Cloud.

Customers. People who have bought or subscribed.

Subscriber keys. The unique identifier of a subscriber in Email Studio. Use a stable customer ID.

Contact keys. The unique identifier of a contact in Contact Builder. Usually the same value as the subscriber key.

Contact IDs. A system-generated internal ID for a contact.

Email addresses. Delivery addresses; they can change, so they should not be the key.

Contact lifecycle. How contacts are created, updated, kept and deleted over time.

4.2 Contact Model: every topic explained

Contact model versus subscriber model. The subscriber model is email-centric; the contact model is cross-channel and keyed by contact key.

Contact Builder. The tool to view contacts, relationships, data extensions and imports.

All Contacts. The list of all contacts across channels in the account.

All Subscribers. The master list of email subscribers and their status.

Contact deletion. Removing contacts and their channel data when required, using the contact deletion process.

Contact status. Whether the contact is active or marked for deletion.

Subscription status. Per-list and global subscription status (active, unsubscribed, held, bounced).

Contact relationships. Links between a contact and their data in other data extensions.

4.3 SFMC Data Architecture: every topic explained

Data architecture fundamentals. How data is organised, stored, linked and governed.

Relational data concepts. Data in tables with rows and columns, linked by keys.

Data relationships. One-to-one, one-to-many and many-to-many links between tables.

Primary keys. A field (or fields) that uniquely identifies each row.

Foreign keys. A field that points to a primary key in another table.

Data normalisation. Splitting data into related tables to remove duplication.

Data extensions. The custom tables in SFMC.

Data views. System tables of tracking data, queried with SQL.

Shared data extensions. Data extensions in the shared folder used by several business units.

4.4 Data Modelling: every topic explained

Customer data model. Core customer table: key, name, contact details, consent, attributes.

Transaction data model. Orders and order lines linked to customers.

Product data model. Products with ID, name, category and price for recommendations.

Campaign data model. Campaigns and sends with IDs to link tracking to business results.

Consent data model. Consent records: channel, purpose, date and source.

Event data model. Events such as page views, cart events and app actions with timestamps.

Contact relationship modelling. Diagram of how all these tables relate to the contact.

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MODULE 5 HANDBOOK

Module 5: Data Extensions and Data Management

5 sections, 39 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 5: Data Extensions and Data Management

Level: Beginner. Data extensions: how they are created, imported, updated and kept clean.

Contents

1. 5.1 Data Extension Fundamentals
2. 5.2 Data Extension Configuration
3. 5.3 Data Operations
4. 5.4 Data Management
5. 5.5 Data Sources

Detailed lessons

Module 5

5.1 Creating and configuring data extensions

WHAT IS IT?

> A data extension is an SFMC table. Types: standard, sendable (linked to a subscriber key and used for sends), non-sendable, and test. Each has fields with types, a primary key, nullable settings and retention settings.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Choosing the right type and key decides whether the data can be used for sending and how long it stays.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create a data extension from the Email Studio or Contact Builder navigation.
2. Add fields with the right type (Text, Number, Date, Email, Phone, Boolean).
3. Set the primary key and make key fields non-nullable.
4. Set retention, for example delete all records after 365 days.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A sendable data extension for customers with SubscriberKey as the send relationship field.

COMMON ERRORS

Choosing text for dates, so date filters fail.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a sendable data extension?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Create a customers data extension with five fields and a primary key in a sandbox account (or write the design if you have no account).

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 5

5.2 Importing, updating and cleaning data

WHAT IS IT?

> Data can be imported from CSV files, SFTP, Salesforce CRM, APIs and databases. Import options include overwrite, append, and update or insert on the primary key. Data quality checks catch duplicates, bad dates and missing keys.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Bad imports send emails to the wrong people. Validate before loading.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Prepare the CSV with a header row matching the field names.
2. Use the import activity with the update-or-insert option on the primary key.
3. Check row counts before and after the import.
4. Remove duplicates with a SQL query before the send.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Import 10,000 rows; the import reports 9,980 rows, so 20 rows had duplicate keys.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
-- Find duplicate keys before a send
SELECT SubscriberKey, COUNT(*) AS Copies
FROM Customers
GROUP BY SubscriberKey
HAVING COUNT(*) > 1;
```

COMMON ERRORS

Choosing overwrite when append was intended, and losing history.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you import daily customer updates without creating duplicates?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Import a sample CSV with planted duplicates and fix them with an import option and a SQL check.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: import data

5.1 Data Extension Fundamentals: every topic explained

What is a data extension?. A table in SFMC with defined fields, used to store data and audiences.

Standard data extensions. A regular data extension with fields you define.

Sendable data extensions. A data extension with a send relationship to subscriber key, so it can be used as a send audience.

Non-sendable data extensions. A data extension used for lookups and reference data, not for sending.

Test data extensions. A data extension marked for tests, so test sends use it.

Shared data extensions. Data extensions shared across business units from the parent.

Data extension templates. Predefined structures that create data extensions with required fields.

5.2 Data Extension Configuration: every topic explained

Creating data extensions. Create from Email Studio or Contact Builder, give a name, external key and fields.

Field configuration. Each field has a name, type, length, primary key flag, nullable flag and default value.

Field types. Text, Number, Decimal, Date, Boolean, EmailAddress, Phone and Locale.

Primary keys. The field(s) that make each row unique and drive update-or-insert imports.

Nullable fields. Whether a field can be empty. Key fields must not be nullable.

Default values. A value used when none is provided, such as today's date.

Send relationships. Links a sendable data extension field to the subscriber key.

Retention settings. Rules to delete rows or the whole data extension after a period.

Data extension permissions. Who can read, edit or delete the data extension, by role and folder.

5.3 Data Operations: every topic explained

Importing data. Loading data from files or connectors into a data extension.

Exporting data. Writing data extension rows to a file with a Data Extract activity.

Updating records. Changing existing rows by key.

Overwriting records. Replacing all rows with the new file.

Appending records. Adding rows without checking for existing keys.

Updating and inserting records. Updating rows that exist and inserting new ones, by primary key.

Import activities. Automation Studio activities that import files into data extensions on a schedule.

File transfer activities. Moving files between the SFTP and the safehouse, and unzipping or decrypting them.

5.4 Data Management: every topic explained

Data retention. Keeping data only as long as needed, set per data extension.

Data deletion. Removing rows or whole tables as policy or requests require.

Duplicate handling. Finding and removing duplicate keys before sending.

Data validation. Checking formats, ranges and required fields on import.

Data cleansing. Fixing or removing bad values.

Data standardisation. Making formats consistent: case, phone format, date format.

Data quality. Overall accuracy, completeness and consistency of the data.

Data governance. Ownership, rules and audits for marketing data.

5.5 Data Sources: every topic explained

CSV. Comma-separated files, the most common import format.

TXT. Plain text files with other delimiters, such as tab or pipe.

SFTP. The secure FTP server in the account used to exchange files.

Salesforce CRM. Data synchronised from Sales or Service Cloud through the connector.

API integrations. Data pushed or pulled with the REST or SOAP APIs.

External databases. Data exported from other systems into files or via middleware.

Cloud storage. Storage such as cloud buckets reached through file transfer or integration tools.

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MODULE 6 HANDBOOK

Module 6: SQL for Salesforce Marketing Cloud

6 sections, 62 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 6: SQL for Salesforce Marketing Cloud

Level: Beginner to intermediate. SQL in SFMC: query activities, the supported syntax, aggregation, joins, data views and common audience queries.

Contents

1. 6.1 SQL Fundamentals
2. 6.2 SQL Aggregations
3. 6.3 SQL Joins
4. 6.4 Advanced SQL
5. 6.5 SFMC Data Views
6. 6.6 SFMC SQL Use Cases

Detailed lessons

Module 6

6.1 SQL fundamentals in SFMC

WHAT IS IT?

> SFMC SQL runs in Query Activities inside Automation Studio. It uses a T-SQL style syntax with some restrictions compared with SQL Server. Core clauses: SELECT, FROM, WHERE, GROUP BY, HAVING, ORDER BY.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Audiences, reports and suppression lists are almost always built with SQL in SFMC.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Write the query in the Query Activity.
2. Set a target data extension and an update option (overwrite or append).
3. Run the activity, then check the row count in the target.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Select active customers from the Customers data extension into an Audience data extension.

COMMON ERRORS

Writing a query that works in SQL Server but is not supported in SFMC. Always test in the Query Activity.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a Query Activity?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a query that selects customers in one city and counts them.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- SFMC SQL reference (Salesforce docs)

6.2 Aggregation, joins and CTEs

WHAT IS IT?

> Aggregates (COUNT, SUM, AVG, MIN, MAX) with GROUP BY summarise data. JOIN combines data extensions and system data views. Common table expressions (WITH) name steps. Check the official SQL restrictions for the exact features your account supports.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Joins and aggregates produce segments and reports; a wrong join silently changes audience size.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use INNER JOIN when both sides must match.
2. Use LEFT JOIN to keep all customers and show missing orders as NULL.
3. Count distinct customers, not rows, when a customer has many orders.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Customers with no order in 90 days: LEFT JOIN orders and keep rows where the order is NULL.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
-- Customers with no order in the last 90 days
SELECT c.SubscriberKey, c.EmailAddress
FROM Customers c
LEFT JOIN Orders o
  ON o.SubscriberKey = c.SubscriberKey
  AND o.OrderDate ⩾ DATEADD(day, -90, GETDATE())
WHERE o.OrderID IS NULL;
-- Line by line: LEFT JOIN keeps every customer; the date condition is inside the join so only
recent orders match;
-- WHERE o.OrderID IS NULL keeps customers with no matching recent order.
```

COMMON ERRORS

Counting rows where you need distinct customers.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain the difference between INNER JOIN and LEFT JOIN.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the 90-day inactivity query and explain each line.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- SFMC SQL reference (Salesforce docs)

Module 6

6.3 SFMC data views

WHAT IS IT?

> System data views hold sends, opens, clicks, bounces, unsubscribes, jobs, journey activity and SMS tracking. Examples: _Subscribers, _Sent, _Open, _Click, _Bounce, _Unsubscribe, _Job, _Journey, _JourneyActivity, _SMSMessageTracking, _Complaint, _BusinessUnitUnsubscribes. Each has its own keys and retention limit.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Engagement analysis and suppression depend on these views. Retention limits mean old data may be gone, so keep your own history.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Check the view's documentation for keys and retention.
2. Join on SubscriberKey and JobID where the view supports them.
3. Export long-term history to your own data extension.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Last-open date per subscriber: SELECT SubscriberKey, MAX(EventDate) FROM _Open GROUP BY SubscriberKey.

COMMON ERRORS

Assuming a data view keeps data forever.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is _Open used for and what limits apply?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

List the data views you would use for an engagement report and state each key and retention limit (verify on the docs).

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- SFMC data views (Salesforce docs)

6.1 SQL Fundamentals: every topic explained

Introduction to SQL. SQL selects and shapes data. In SFMC it runs in Query Activities and writes results to a target data extension.

SELECT. Chooses the columns to return.

FROM. Names the data extension or data view to read.

WHERE. Filters rows by a condition.

DISTINCT. Removes duplicate rows from the result.

ORDER BY. Sorts the result. In SFMC Query Activities ordering is often not needed because results go to a table.

TOP. Returns only the first N rows (T-SQL style), often with ORDER BY.

AND and OR. Combine conditions; AND needs both, OR needs either.

IN. Matches any value in a list.

BETWEEN. Matches a range, inclusive at both ends.

LIKE. Pattern match with % (any characters) and _ (one character).

IS NULL. Finds missing values. NULL is not equal to anything, so use IS NULL.

CASE WHEN. If-then logic inside a query to create labels or segments.

6.2 SQL Aggregations: every topic explained

COUNT. Counts rows; COUNT(DISTINCT x) counts unique values.

SUM. Adds numeric values.

AVG. Average of numeric values.

MIN. Smallest value.

MAX. Largest value.

GROUP BY. Groups rows to aggregate per group.

HAVING. Filters groups after aggregation.

6.3 SQL Joins: every topic explained

INNER JOIN. Keeps rows that match in both tables.

LEFT JOIN. Keeps all rows from the left table, matched rows from the right or NULL.

RIGHT JOIN. Keeps all rows from the right table. Usually rewritten as a LEFT JOIN for clarity.

FULL OUTER JOIN concepts. Keeps all rows from both sides. Check support and performance before using it in SFMC.

SELF JOIN. Joins a table to itself, for example to compare rows of the same customer.

Multiple joins. Chains several joins; check row counts after each join.

Joining data extensions. Joins customers to orders or preferences on the subscriber key.

Joining system data views. Joins your data to data views such as _Open on SubscriberKey or JobID.

6.4 Advanced SQL: every topic explained

Subqueries. A query inside another query, used in WHERE or FROM.

Common Table Expressions. Named temporary results with WITH that make long queries readable. Check SFMC's SQL reference for support in your account.

Window functions. Functions that compute over related rows without collapsing them.

ROW_NUMBER. Numbers rows within a partition; used to keep the latest row per customer.

RANK. Ranks with gaps after ties.

DENSE_RANK. Ranks without gaps after ties.

PARTITION BY. Splits rows into groups for window functions.

LAG and LEAD concepts. Read the previous or next row's value. Check support before relying on them.

Date functions. GETDATE, DATEADD, DATEDIFF and CONVERT for date work.

String functions. LEFT, RIGHT, SUBSTRING, LEN, UPPER, LOWER, LTRIM and RTRIM.

Conversion functions. CAST and CONVERT change data types.

Null handling. ISNULL and COALESCE replace NULL values.

6.5 SFMC Data Views: every topic explained

_Subscribers. Subscriber records with status and dates. Check the docs for availability per business unit.

_Sent. One row per email sent, with JobID, SubscriberKey and EventDate.

_Open. One row per open, with event date and unique flag.

_Click. One row per click, with link URL and event date.

_Bounce. Bounce events with category and type (hard or soft).

_Unsubscribe. Unsubscribe events.

_Job. Send jobs with email name, subject and send dates.

_Journey. Journey versions and status.

_JourneyActivity. Activities inside journeys, linked to JourneyVersionID.

_SMSMessageTracking. SMS send and delivery tracking.

_Complaint. Spam complaints from mailbox providers.

_BusinessUnitUnsubscribes. Unsubscribes at business-unit level.

6.6 SFMC SQL Use Cases: every topic explained

Subscriber segmentation. Selecting audiences by attributes, behaviour and consent.

Campaign performance analysis. Sends, opens, clicks and bounces per job from data views.

Email engagement analysis. Open and click history per subscriber.

Bounce analysis. Bounce reasons by domain and campaign to fix list quality.

Unsubscribe analysis. Unsubscribe trends by campaign and segment.

Customer inactivity. Customers with no open, click or purchase in a set period.

Journey entry segmentation. Audiences built for a journey's data extension entry source.

Purchase history analysis. Orders by customer, product and date for targeting.

Customer retention. Repeat purchase and lapse measures.

Re-engagement audiences. Inactive but recoverable customers for win-back journeys.

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MODULE 7 HANDBOOK

Module 7: Email Studio

5 sections, 41 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
Edition: November 2026. Practice labs marked "account" need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account. Other labs use sample files or paper.

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Module 7: Email Studio

Level: Beginner to intermediate. Email Studio: sends, subscriber status, suppression and deliverability.

Contents

1. 7.1 Email Studio Fundamentals
2. 7.2 Email Sending
3. 7.3 Subscriber Management
4. 7.4 Email Deliverability
5. 7.5 Advanced Email Campaigns

Detailed lessons

Module 7

7.1 Sends, classifications and subscriber status

WHAT IS IT?

> An email send is a definition with a data source, a send classification (commercial or transactional, depending on the law and consent), a sender profile and a delivery profile. Subscriber status includes active, unsubscribed, bounced and held.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Sending commercial email to unsubscribed people breaks the law in many places and damages reputation.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create the email, then the send definition.
2. Choose the send classification that matches the message (commercial needs consent and an unsubscribe link).
3. Use suppression lists for people who must not receive the message.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A password reset is transactional; a promotion is commercial with unsubscribe.

COMMON ERRORS

Using a commercial classification for transactional mail, or the reverse.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a send classification?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Classify five sample messages and explain each choice.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 7

7.2 Deliverability: SPF, DKIM, DMARC and bounce management

WHAT IS IT?

> SPF lists the servers allowed to send for a domain; DKIM signs messages; DMARC tells receivers what to do when checks fail. Bounces are hard (invalid address) or soft (temporary). Complaints and bounce rates affect reputation.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Good deliverability decides whether the message is seen at all.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Publish SPF and DKIM for the sending domain.
2. Add a DMARC policy starting with monitoring (p=none).
3. Remove hard-bounced addresses from the send.
4. Watch complaint rates after each send.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A hard bounce is suppressed automatically; a soft bounce is retried by the system.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending to old lists without removing bounces.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does DMARC do?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a deliverability checklist for a new sending domain.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Google: email sender guidelines

7.1 Email Studio Fundamentals: every topic explained

Email Studio interface. The studio for creating, sending and tracking email.

Email campaign lifecycle. Plan, build, test, send, measure, improve.

Email creation. Build in Content Builder with templates and blocks.

Email templates. Reusable layouts with editable regions.

Email assets. Images, blocks and documents used in emails.

Email classifications. Commercial or transactional classification attached to sends.

7.2 Email Sending: every topic explained

Send definitions. Saved settings for a send: email, audience, classification and options.

User-initiated sends. Sends started by a user (manual or scheduled).

Triggered sends. Sends started by an API call or event, such as a receipt.

Test sends. Sends to test audiences before the real send.

Guided sends where applicable. Step-by-step send flow in the interface where available.

Send scheduling. Setting a future send time.

Audience selection. Choosing lists or data extensions and exclusions.

Send classifications. The legal and delivery settings applied to the send.

7.3 Subscriber Management: every topic explained

Subscriber status. Active, unsubscribed, held or bounced, per subscriber.

Active subscribers. Subscribers who can receive email.

Unsubscribed subscribers. Opted out; they must not receive commercial email.

Bounced subscribers. Addresses that bounced; repeated hard bounces lead to held status.

Held subscribers. Addresses held after too many bounces; they are not sent to.

Suppression lists. Lists of addresses never to be sent to.

Publication lists. Lists that track opt-in by topic or purpose.

Global unsubscribes. Opt-outs that apply across the account.

7.4 Email Deliverability: every topic explained

SPF. A DNS record listing servers allowed to send for a domain.

DKIM. A signature that proves the message was not changed and came from the domain.

DMARC. A policy telling receivers how to handle mail that fails SPF or DKIM, with reports.

Sender authentication. The SFMC setup that applies SPF, DKIM and branded domains to sends.

IP reputation. The reputation of the sending IP address with mailbox providers.

Domain reputation. The reputation of the sending domain.

Dedicated versus shared IP. Dedicated IPs carry only your reputation; shared IPs are shared with other senders.

Email throttling. Spreading a large send over time to protect reputation.

Bounce management. Processing hard and soft bounces and removing bad addresses.

Spam complaints. Complaints from recipients marking mail as spam; keep them very low.

Inbox placement. Whether mail lands in the inbox, promotions or spam folder.

7.5 Advanced Email Campaigns: every topic explained

Dynamic content. Content that changes by subscriber data or rules.

Personalised email. Email that uses the subscriber's data, such as name and recent products.

A/B testing. Testing two versions (subject, content) on part of the audience, then sending the winner.

Send-time optimisation. Sending at the time each subscriber is most likely to engage, where the feature is licensed.

Segmented campaigns. Different messages for different segments.

Triggered email. Email sent automatically on an event.

Transactional messaging. Receipts and account notices, sent with a transactional classification.

Campaign reporting. Tracking and reports on send performance.

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MODULE 8 HANDBOOK

Module 8: Content Builder and Email Development

4 sections, 31 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
Edition: November 2026. Practice labs marked "account" need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account. Other labs use sample files or paper.

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Module 8: Content Builder and Email Development

Level: Beginner to intermediate. Content Builder assets, responsive email design and dynamic content.

Contents

1. 8.1 Content Builder
2. 8.2 Email Design
3. 8.3 Dynamic Content
4. 8.4 Email Testing

Detailed lessons

Module 8

8.1 Content Builder assets and naming

WHAT IS IT?

> Content Builder stores emails, images, content blocks and templates in folders. Naming conventions make assets findable and safe to reuse.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Teams lose time looking for assets, and reused blocks change without warning if the naming and sharing are wrong.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create folders by brand, campaign type and year.
2. Name blocks with a prefix such as blk_footer_brandA.
3. Use shared content blocks for footers and legal text.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> blk_footer_brandA is used in 40 emails; one edit updates them all.

COMMON ERRORS

Editing a shared block without checking every email that uses it.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you organise Content Builder for three brands?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a folder and naming structure for two brands.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

8.2 Responsive HTML email

WHAT IS IT?

Email HTML uses table-based layouts, inline CSS and media queries for mobile. Email clients have different support, so test in several clients.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

Most emails are opened on phones; a layout that breaks on mobile loses clicks.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use a single-column table layout with a maximum width of 600px.
2. Inline the key styles.
3. Use alt text on images and a text fallback for buttons.
4. Test on mobile and desktop clients.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

A two-column layout collapses to one column below 480px using a media query.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<body style="margin:0;background:#f4f4f7;font-family:Arial,sans-serif">
<table role="presentation" width="100%" cellpadding="0" cellspacing="0"><tr><td align="center">
  <table role="presentation" width="600" style="max-width:600px;background:#ffffff">
    <tr><td style="padding:24px;text-align:center;font-size:22px;font-
weight:bold;color:#2b1a66">Your new offers</td></tr>
    <tr><td style="padding:0 24px 24px;font-size:16px;color:#1d1b2e">
      Hi %%=ProperCase(AttributeValue("FirstName"))=%%, here are picks for you.
    </td></tr>
    <tr><td align="center" style="padding:0 24px 32px">
      <a href="https://example.com/offer" style="background:#5b37c9;color:#ffffff;padding:12px
22px;text-decoration:none;border-radius:6px">See offers</a>
    </td></tr>
  </table>
</td></tr></table>
</body>
</html>
```

COMMON ERRORS

Relying on CSS features that many clients ignore.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Why are email layouts built with tables?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Build a 600px responsive promotional email with a header, hero, two columns and a button.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Campaign Monitor: HTML email guide

8.1 Content Builder: every topic explained

Content Builder interface. The library to create and organise content.

Asset management. Creating, editing, reusing and archiving assets.

Folder organisation. Folders by brand, campaign and type.

Content blocks. Reusable pieces such as headers, footers and offers.

Templates. Layouts that emails start from.

Images. Uploaded images, optimised for email size.

Documents. Files such as PDFs linked from emails.

Dynamic content. Blocks whose content changes by rules.

Reusable content. Blocks shared in many emails so one edit updates them all.

Asset naming conventions. Consistent asset names for findability.

8.2 Email Design: every topic explained

Email layout. Header, hero, body, call to action and footer in a clear hierarchy.

Responsive email design. Layouts that adapt to screen size.

Email rendering. How email clients display HTML; each client differs.

Mobile compatibility. Readable on phones: single column, large text and tappable buttons.

Accessibility. Alt text, contrast, real text instead of images of text, and a logical reading order.

Typography. Web-safe font stacks and readable sizes.

Image optimisation. Compressed images with correct width and height.

Call-to-action design. Clear, single primary action with a visible button.

8.3 Dynamic Content: every topic explained

Dynamic content blocks. Blocks that show different content by audience rules.

Personalisation. Inserting subscriber data into content.

Conditional content. Show or hide sections based on data.

Content rules. The conditions that decide which content variant shows.

Audience-based content. Content variants for segments.

Personalised recommendations. Product suggestions based on data or a recommendation feed.

8.4 Email Testing: every topic explained

Preview and test. Preview the email and send tests.

Subscriber preview. Preview as a specific subscriber to check personalisation.

Personalisation testing. Check personalisation with missing and unusual values.

Link testing. Click every link and check tracking.

Rendering testing. Check display in major email clients with a testing tool.

Mobile testing. Check on phones and narrow screens.

Email client compatibility. Confirm the email works in the clients your audience uses.

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MODULE 9 HANDBOOK

Module 9: AMPscript Programming

7 sections, 60 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
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Module 9: AMPscript Programming

Level: Intermediate. AMPscript: syntax, variables, personalisation, data extension lookups and debugging.

Contents

1. 9.1 AMPscript Fundamentals
2. 9.2 Variables and Data
3. 9.3 Personalisation
4. 9.4 Conditional Logic
5. 9.5 Data Extension Functions
6. 9.6 Advanced AMPscript
7. 9.7 AMPscript Debugging

Detailed lessons

Module 9

9.1 Syntax, variables and personalisation

WHAT IS IT?

> AMPscript runs on the server inside %%[...]%% blocks and prints values with %%=...=%%. SET assigns a variable; AttributeValue reads a subscriber attribute; ProperCase formats names.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Almost every personalised SFMC email or CloudPage uses AMPscript.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Declare with VAR and assign with SET.
2. Print with %%= ... =%%.
3. Use AttributeValue for subscriber fields and provide a default in IIF or a check.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Hello %%=ProperCase(AttributeValue("FirstName"))=%%.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
%%[
  VAR @first, @greeting
  SET @first = AttributeValue("FirstName")
  IF Empty(@first) THEN
    SET @greeting = "there"
  ELSE
    SET @greeting = ProperCase(@first)
  ENDIF
]%%
Hello %%=v(@greeting)=%%,
// Line by line: VAR declares the variables; SET reads the subscriber's first name;
// IF/ELSE chooses the fallback when the field is empty; v() prints the variable.
```

COMMON ERRORS

Printing an empty first name, which shows 'Hello ,'.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does AttributeValue return if the attribute is missing?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a greeting that falls back to 'there' if FirstName is empty.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- AMPscript guide (Salesforce docs)

Module 9

9.2 Data extension lookups

WHAT IS IT?

> Lookup returns one value from a data extension by matching a field. LookupRows returns a set of rows. RowCount counts them. Always handle the case when nothing is found.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Lookups personalise messages from other data (orders, loyalty points) without a separate send.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use Lookup('DataExtension','ReturnField','MatchField',value).
2. Check RowCount on LookupRows before looping.
3. Use the subscriber key or email address as the match value.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Show the loyalty points for the subscriber's email.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
%%[
  VAR @tier
  SET @tier = Lookup("LoyaltyMembers", "Tier", "EmailAddress", emailaddr)
  IF Empty(@tier) THEN SET @tier = "Member" ENDIF
]%%
Your tier: %%=v(@tier)=%%
// Lookup matches EmailAddress to the subscriber email (emailaddr); if no row, @tier is empty and
the default is used.
```

COMMON ERRORS

Lookup on a field that is not unique and returns a random row.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain Lookup and LookupRows.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Show the loyalty tier with a Lookup and a default when no row exists.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- AMPscript guide (Salesforce docs)

9.1 AMPscript Fundamentals: every topic explained

What is AMPscript?. AMPscript is Salesforce Marketing Cloud's scripting language for personalising emails, SMS, CloudPages and landing pages at send or page-load time.

AMPscript execution. It runs on SFMC servers when the message is built or the page loads, not in the recipient's email client or browser.

Syntax. Code blocks use %%[...]%%; inline output uses %%= ... =%%; functions take arguments in brackets.

Variables. Named values that start with @, such as @firstName.

Functions. Built-in operations such as Lookup, Concat, Format and ProperCase.

Inline AMPscript. Short expressions printed directly in content with %%= ... =%%.

AMPscript blocks. Multi-line logic between %%[and]%%, used to set variables and run conditions.

Output expressions. The printed result of an expression, such as %%=v(@firstName)=%%.

9.2 Variables and Data: every topic explained

SET. Assigns a value: SET @x = 1.

SETROW. Sets the row set returned by LookupRows into a variable for looping (used with Row and Field).

Variable declaration. VAR declares variables before use: VAR @a, @b.

Data types. AMPscript values are strings, numbers, dates, booleans or row sets.

String variables. Text values in double quotes.

Numeric variables. Numbers used in maths and comparisons.

Date variables. Dates used with DateAdd, DateDiff and FormatDate.

9.3 Personalisation: every topic explained

AttributeValue. Returns the value of a subscriber or sendable data extension field, or an empty value if missing.

ProperCase. Capitalises the first letter of each word.

Uppercase. Converts text to upper case.

Lowercase. Converts text to lower case.

Substring. Returns part of a string from a start position and length.

Concat. Joins strings together.

Format functions. Format and FormatDate change how numbers and dates display.

Default values. Use Empty() checks or IIF to provide a fallback value.

Conditional personalisation. Show different text based on data, such as tier or city.

9.4 Conditional Logic: every topic explained

IF. Runs code when a condition is true.

ELSEIF. Checks another condition when the first is false.

ELSE. Runs when no condition is true.

FOR loops. Repeats for a counter range, often over rows from LookupRows.

WHILE loops. Repeats while a condition holds. Use with care to avoid loops that never end.

Conditional rendering. Show content only when a condition is met.

Dynamic content logic. Choose content variants with IF logic based on subscriber data.

9.5 Data Extension Functions: every topic explained

Lookup. Returns one field value from the first row that matches.

LookupRows. Returns all rows that match one or more field values.

LookupOrderedRows. Returns matching rows sorted and limited by count.

LookupRowsCS. Case-sensitive version of LookupRows.

LookupOrderedRowsCS. Case-sensitive version of LookupOrderedRows.

Row. Gets a row by position from a row set.

RowCount. Counts rows in a row set; check it before looping.

Field. Reads a field from a row.

InsertDE. Inserts a row into a data extension (in emails, inserts at send time).

UpdateDE. Updates rows that match keys.

UpsertDE. Updates or inserts by key, often used on CloudPages.

DeleteDE. Deletes rows that match keys.

RetrieveSalesforceObjects where supported. Reads Salesforce CRM objects where the connector is set up and the context supports it.

9.6 Advanced AMPscript: every topic explained

Error handling. Guard every lookup and value with checks so a missing value does not break the message.

Personalised URLs. Build links with subscriber parameters, encoded safely.

Dynamic images. Choose image URLs from data, such as a product image.

Dynamic content. Show content blocks by rules or data.

Date calculations. DateAdd, DateDiff and FormatDate for expiry dates and reminders.

Subscriber-specific content. Content based on the subscriber's own data.

Data extension lookups. Reading related data such as orders or loyalty points at send time.

Email personalisation. Names, offers, products and dates personalised in email.

CloudPages personalisation. Reading request parameters and writing to data extensions on pages.

9.7 AMPscript Debugging: every topic explained

Common errors. Syntax errors, wrong function names, missing quotes and missing ENDIF.

Invalid field references. A field name that does not exist in the data source.

Lookup errors. Lookups on fields that are not unique, or data extensions with wrong names.

Missing values. Empty values when data is missing; always provide defaults.

Syntax errors. Unclosed blocks or brackets that stop the preview.

Preview troubleshooting. Preview with several test subscribers to find data problems.

Performance considerations. Many lookups per message slow sends; pre-join data with SQL where possible.

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MODULE 10 HANDBOOK

Module 10: HTML, CSS and JavaScript for SFMC

5 sections, 40 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
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Module 10: HTML, CSS and JavaScript for SFMC

Level: Beginner to intermediate. The web basics needed for emails and CloudPages, and where JavaScript is used in SFMC.

Contents

1. 10.1 HTML Fundamentals
2. 10.2 CSS Fundamentals
3. 10.3 Email HTML
4. 10.4 JavaScript Fundamentals
5. 10.5 SFMC Development Applications

Detailed lessons

Module 10

10.1 HTML and CSS essentials for SFMC

WHAT IS IT?

> HTML gives structure (headings, paragraphs, links, images, tables, forms). CSS gives style (colours, spacing, fonts). In email, styles must be inlined and tables used for layout.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> You cannot fix a broken email or landing page without these basics.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Learn tags: h1, p, a, img, table, tr, td.
2. Learn selectors and properties.
3. Inline styles for email clients.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A link is an a tag with an href attribute.

COMMON ERRORS

Using div-based layouts in email.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is the difference between HTML and CSS?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Build a simple page with a heading, a paragraph and a link.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- MDN: HTML basics (official)

Module 10

10.2 JavaScript in CloudPages and forms

WHAT IS IT?

> JavaScript runs in the browser and can validate forms. Server-side JavaScript (SSJS) runs in SFMC for data work and is different from browser JavaScript. Keep secrets off the browser.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Forms and interactive pages need validation before data is saved.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Validate the email format before submit.
2. Show error messages next to fields.
3. Use SSJS only where the platform supports it and check the docs.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A registration form that checks the email format before posting.

COMMON ERRORS

Trusting browser validation alone; always validate on the server too.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Where would you run JavaScript in an SFMC project?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a browser check for an email field.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

10.1 HTML Fundamentals: every topic explained

HTML document structure. doctype, html, head and body elements.

Tags and elements. Elements are created with opening and closing tags.

Headings and paragraphs. h1 to h6 headings and p paragraphs.

Links. a tags with href attributes.

Images. img tags with src, alt, width and height.

Tables. table, tr and td for layout in email.

Forms. form, input, label, select and button for data capture.

Attributes. Extra settings on elements, such as href and alt.

10.2 CSS Fundamentals: every topic explained

Selectors. Choose elements to style: tag, class and id selectors.

Properties. Style rules such as colour, font-size and padding.

Classes and IDs. Classes style groups; IDs identify one element.

Typography. Fonts, sizes, weights and line height.

Colours. Hex or RGB colours with enough contrast.

Spacing. Margin and padding.

Layout. Positioning and flow; in email, tables manage layout.

Responsive styling. Media queries change styles on small screens.

10.3 Email HTML: every topic explained

Table-based email layouts. Tables give reliable layout across email clients.

Inline CSS. Styles written on each element, because many clients strip style blocks.

Responsive email design. Designs that adapt to phone screens.

Media queries. Rules that apply styles only at certain widths.

Outlook compatibility. Outlook uses a Word-based rendering engine; use tables and conditional comments.

Gmail compatibility. Gmail supports some style blocks; test clipping and image blocking.

Email rendering limitations. Limited CSS support, no scripts and image blocking by default in some clients.

10.4 JavaScript Fundamentals: every topic explained

Variables. let and const store values.

Data types. Strings, numbers, booleans, objects and arrays.

Functions. Reusable blocks of code.

Conditions. if and else.

Loops. for and while.

Objects. Key-value data.

Arrays. Ordered lists of values.

DOM concepts. The page as objects that scripts can read and change.

Event handling. Reacting to clicks and form submits.

10.5 SFMC Development Applications: every topic explained

HTML emails. Emails built with tables, inline CSS and AMPscript.

CloudPages. Hosted pages for forms and content.

Landing pages. Pages for campaigns and offers.

Forms. Data capture with validation.

Personalisation. Data-driven content in emails and pages.

Interactive experiences. Interactive email (where supported) and interactive pages.

Server-side JavaScript fundamentals. SSJS runs on SFMC servers for data and API work in pages and automations.

Platform-specific limitations. Some JavaScript, CSS and libraries do not work in email or in SFMC pages; test first.

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MODULE 11 HANDBOOK

Module 11: Journey Builder

5 sections, 43 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
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Module 11: Journey Builder

Level: Intermediate. Journeys: entry sources, activities, splits, testing and troubleshooting.

Contents

1. 11.1 Journey Builder Fundamentals
2. 11.2 Entry Sources
3. 11.3 Journey Activities
4. 11.4 Advanced Journey Design
5. 11.5 Journey Testing and Monitoring

Detailed lessons

Module 11

11.1 Entry sources and activities

WHAT IS IT?

> A journey starts with an entry source (data extension, API event, Salesforce data, audience) and moves contacts through activities: email, SMS, push, wait, decision splits, engagement splits, random splits and update contact.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Journeys deliver the multi-step experiences customers expect, from welcome series to renewal reminders.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Choose an entry source that updates in near real time for triggered journeys.
2. Add an email activity and a wait activity.
3. Add a decision split on a data field (for example, plan type).

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Welcome journey: entry on sign-up, welcome email, wait 2 days, decision split on first login.

COMMON ERRORS

Entering contacts from a data extension that is refreshed once a week and expecting real-time triggers.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is an entry source and how do you choose one?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a three-step welcome journey on paper with entry, email, wait and a split.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Journey Builder documentation (Salesforce)

Module 11

11.2 Re-entry, exit criteria and testing

WHAT IS IT?

> Re-entry rules decide whether a contact can enter again. Exit criteria stop contacts who have completed or unsubscribed. Test with a test data extension before activating.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A wrong re-entry rule either floods a contact with messages or stops them from ever re-entering.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Set re-entry rules explicitly.
2. Add an exit on unsubscribe.
3. Test with a small test population, then review contact tracking.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Abandoned cart: re-entry allowed after 7 days, exit when the order completes.

COMMON ERRORS

Leaving re-entry at default without checking.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you troubleshoot a journey that does not accept contacts?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the test plan for an abandoned cart journey.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

11.1 Journey Builder Fundamentals: every topic explained

What is Journey Builder?. The tool to build multi-step, multi-channel journeys.

Journey architecture. Entry source, activities, splits, waits and exits on a canvas.

Customer journey concepts. A sequence of messages and decisions that follows customer behaviour.

Journey creation. Create the journey, choose the entry source and add activities.

Journey configuration. Settings such as re-entry, goals, exit criteria and contact evaluation.

Journey activation. Validate and activate; changes after activation create new versions.

11.2 Entry Sources: every topic explained

Data Extension Entry Source. Contacts enter from a data extension on a schedule or when rows are added.

API Event. Contacts enter when an external system calls the API with event data.

Salesforce Data Entry. Contacts enter when Salesforce CRM records are created or changed (needs the connector).

Audience Entry. Contacts enter from an audience, for example from Data Cloud where licensed.

Automation-related entry. An automation populates the data extension used by the entry source.

Entry event configuration. Defines the data schema and how entries are evaluated.

Entry filters. Rules that limit who enters.

Re-entry rules. Whether a contact can enter again: no re-entry, any time, or only after exiting.

11.3 Journey Activities: every topic explained

Email activity. Sends an email to the contact.

SMS activity. Sends an SMS (MobileConnect licence).

Push notification activity. Sends an app push notification (MobilePush licence).

Wait activity. Pauses for a duration, until a date, or until an event.

Decision Split. Routes contacts by data rules.

Engagement Split. Routes by email engagement (opened, clicked, bounced).

Random Split. Splits contacts randomly for tests.

Update Contact. Writes a value to a data extension for tracking.

Salesforce activities where supported. Create or update CRM records from the journey (with the connector).

Custom activities. Partner or custom activities that call external services.

Exit criteria. Rules that remove contacts once a goal or condition is met.

11.4 Advanced Journey Design: every topic explained

Multi-step journeys. Journeys with several messages over days or weeks.

Multi-channel journeys. Journeys that mix email, SMS and push.

Branching logic. Splits that send contacts down different paths.

Customer lifecycle journeys. Onboarding, active, lapsing and win-back stages.

Abandoned cart journeys. Reminders after a cart is abandoned, stopped once the order completes.

Welcome journeys. A series that introduces new customers to the brand.

Renewal journeys. Reminders before a subscription or policy renewal.

Re-engagement journeys. Messages for inactive contacts, with a sunset rule.

Transactional journeys. Receipts and notices as part of a journey.

11.5 Journey Testing and Monitoring: every topic explained

Journey validation. The built-in check that the journey is configured correctly.

Testing. Testing with test contacts and test mode where available.

Entry event testing. Fire test events and check that contacts enter.

Journey versioning. Each change after activation is a new version; manage old versions.

Journey activation. Make it live and monitor the first entries.

Contact tracking. See where a contact is in the journey.

Error handling. Handle failed activities and contacts in error.

Journey performance. Entries, exits, goals and message results.

Troubleshooting. Check entry source, filters, re-entry, data and journey status.

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MODULE 12 HANDBOOK

Module 12: Automation Studio

4 sections, 28 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 12: Automation Studio

Level: Intermediate. Automations: SQL activities, file imports, scheduling and monitoring.

Contents

1. 12.1 Automation Studio Fundamentals
2. 12.2 Automation Activities
3. 12.3 Automation Design
4. 12.4 Advanced Automation

Detailed lessons

Module 12

12.1 Activities and scheduling

WHAT IS IT?

> An automation is a sequence of activities such as SQL Query, Data Extract, File Transfer, Import File, Filter, Script, Verification and send activities, run on a schedule or on file arrival.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Automations prepare audiences and keep data current without manual work.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create the automation, add a SQL Query Activity, then a Data Extract if needed.
2. Set a schedule (daily at 02:00 for example).
3. Run once manually before scheduling.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Daily: import file, run audience query, filter, then send.

COMMON ERRORS

Scheduling before testing the SQL; failures then happen unattended.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you schedule a daily audience build?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Plan an automation with four activities and an order.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 12

12.2 Monitoring, errors and retries

WHAT IS IT?

> Automation status shows which activity failed. Verification activities check files or row counts before the next step. Failure notifications and logs help support teams.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Production failures need fast detection and a clear path back to working data.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Add a verification step after each import.
2. Set failure notifications to the owner.
3. Keep a rerun procedure.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A verification step stops the send if the file has fewer than 1,000 rows.

COMMON ERRORS

No row-count checks, so an empty file sends an empty campaign.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you troubleshoot an automation failure?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a runbook for a failed daily import.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

12.1 Automation Studio Fundamentals: every topic explained

Automation Studio interface. The studio to build, schedule and monitor automations.

Automation architecture. A starting source (schedule or file drop) and steps of activities.

Automation creation. Create an automation and drag activities into steps.

Scheduling. Run hourly, daily, weekly or on file drop.

Automation monitoring. Status and run history for each automation and activity.

12.2 Automation Activities: every topic explained

SQL Query Activity. Runs SQL and writes the result to a target data extension.

Data Extract Activity. Exports data extensions or tracking data to files.

File Transfer Activity. Moves files to or from the SFTP, and decrypts or unzips them.

Import Activity. Loads a file into a data extension.

Filter Activity. Applies a saved filter to create a filtered audience.

Script Activity. Runs server-side JavaScript for advanced data work.

Verification Activity. Checks row counts and stops the automation if a rule fails.

Send activities. Send emails or SMS as a step.

Wait activities. Pause between steps.

12.3 Automation Design: every topic explained

Sequential activities. Steps run one after another; activities in the same step run together.

Scheduled automations. Automations that run on a timetable.

File-triggered workflows. Automations that start when a file arrives in a folder.

Data refresh workflows. Daily or hourly refresh of data from source files.

Audience preparation. Building send audiences with SQL and filters.

Data synchronisation. Keeping SFMC data in line with source systems.

Campaign preparation. Preparing data and sending in one flow.

12.4 Advanced Automation: every topic explained

Multiple automation dependencies. Several automations that must run in order; coordinate schedules or file drops.

Error handling. Verification steps and notifications on failure.

Retry logic. Rerun failed steps once the cause is fixed.

Automation logging. Write run results to a log data extension.

Monitoring. Watch run history and failure alerts daily.

Failure notifications. Email notifications to owners when runs fail.

Automation optimisation. Reduce steps, tune queries and avoid peak times.

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MODULE 13 HANDBOOK

Module 13: Contact Builder and Data Designer

3 sections, 19 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 13: Contact Builder and Data Designer

Level: Intermediate. Contact Builder: attribute groups, relationships and the contact model.

Contents

1. 13.1 Contact Builder Fundamentals
2. 13.2 Attribute Groups
3. 13.3 Contact Management

Detailed lessons

Module 13

13.1 Attribute groups and relationships

WHAT IS IT?

> Attribute groups bring fields from several data extensions into one contact view. One-to-one and one-to-many relationships link them through contact keys.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A clear contact model is the base of multi-business-unit and Customer 360 designs.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create an attribute group from the contact's data extensions.
2. Link tables with the contact key.
3. Check that one contact returns one row per attribute group where expected.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Contact (1) to orders (many): an attribute group for orders shows the most recent order fields.

COMMON ERRORS

Joining one-to-many data and expecting one row per contact.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is an attribute group?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Model a customer with orders and loyalty tables in an attribute group design.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 13

13.2 Contact governance and deletion

WHAT IS IT?

> Contact deletion and retention decide how long personal data is kept. Governance records who owns the model and who may change it.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Retention is a legal requirement in many regions.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define retention per data extension.
2. Document contact deletion requests.
3. Review the contact model yearly.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A deletion request removes the contact and its linked records within the agreed time.

COMMON ERRORS

Keeping personal data forever.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you handle a deletion request in SFMC?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a deletion procedure for a privacy request.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

13.1 Contact Builder Fundamentals: every topic explained

Contact Builder navigation. Contacts, Data Designer, Data Extensions, Imports and Data Sources.

Contact model. How contacts link to channel and custom data.

Contact relationships. Links from the contact to attribute groups and data extensions.

Attribute groups. Groups of related data extensions linked to the contact.

Data Designer. The visual tool to link data extensions to contacts.

13.2 Attribute Groups: every topic explained

Creating attribute groups. Create a group, link a data extension to the contact key, then add related tables.

Data extension relationships. Links defined between fields in data extensions.

One-to-one relationships. One row per contact, such as a profile.

One-to-many relationships. Many rows per contact, such as orders.

Contact key relationships. Relationships that start from the contact key.

Data model design. A clear model for journeys and segmentation.

13.3 Contact Management: every topic explained

Contact deletion. Removing a contact and its data on request.

Contact status. Active or pending deletion.

Contact population. How many contacts the account holds, which can affect licence counts.

Contact identity. Consistent identification across channels.

Subscriber key. Email Studio identifier; keep it equal to the contact key.

Contact key. Contact Builder identifier.

Data retention. Keeping contact data only as long as needed.

Contact governance. Rules and ownership for the contact model.

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MODULE 14 HANDBOOK

Module 14: Mobile Studio and SMS Marketing

5 sections, 29 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 14: Mobile Studio and SMS Marketing

Level: Intermediate. MobileConnect for SMS and MobilePush for app notifications, with opt-in and compliance.

Contents

1. 14.1 Mobile Marketing Fundamentals
2. 14.2 MobileConnect
3. 14.3 MobilePush
4. 14.4 Mobile Automation
5. 14.5 Compliance

Detailed lessons

Module 14

14.1 SMS and MobileConnect

WHAT IS IT?

> MobileConnect sends SMS. Keywords such as START and STOP handle opt-in and opt-out. Sender type (short code or long code) depends on the country and the account.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> SMS is strict on consent and frequency; mistakes lead to blocked messages and fines.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Record opt-in with a keyword or a form.
2. Send only to opted-in mobile numbers.
3. Include the opt-out instruction.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Text START to subscribe; reply STOP to unsubscribe, which is recorded automatically.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending SMS to numbers without consent.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you handle opt-out for SMS?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the opt-in and opt-out messages for a retail SMS programme.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: MobileConnect (verify current docs)

Module 14

14.2 MobilePush and compliance

WHAT IS IT?

> MobilePush sends notifications to mobile apps that register devices. Compliance covers consent, quiet hours, frequency and local messaging rules.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Notifications without consent or at night lose users.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Register devices with the app.
2. Target by segment.
3. Respect quiet hours and frequency caps.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A push at 10:00 local time for an opted-in user.

COMMON ERRORS

Ignoring the local rules for messages.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What checks apply before sending an SMS campaign?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a compliance checklist for SMS and push.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

14.1 Mobile Marketing Fundamentals: every topic explained

Mobile marketing. Reaching customers on phones by SMS, push and in-app messages.

SMS marketing. Text messaging with consent.

Mobile push notifications. Notifications sent to app users.

Mobile customer engagement. Timely, useful mobile messages tied to behaviour.

Omnichannel messaging. Coordinated messages across channels.

14.2 MobileConnect: every topic explained

SMS campaign fundamentals. Plan audience, message, timing and opt-in for SMS.

Short codes and long codes where applicable. Short codes are short numbers for high volume; long codes are normal numbers. Availability depends on country and account.

Keyword management. Keywords like START, STOP and HELP trigger actions.

Opt-in and opt-out. Recording and honouring consent and opt-out.

Mobile subscriptions. Subscriptions per keyword or programme.

SMS personalisation. Inserting data into SMS text with personalisation strings or AMPscript.

SMS delivery tracking. Delivery receipts and tracking.

14.3 MobilePush: every topic explained

Push notification fundamentals. Notifications that appear on a device for app users.

App integration. Integrating the Marketing Cloud mobile SDK into the app.

Device registration. Devices register to receive push.

Push campaigns. Scheduled or triggered push sends.

Audience targeting. Segments of app users.

Personalisation. Personalised push text.

Delivery tracking. Tracking opens and delivery.

14.4 Mobile Automation: every topic explained

SMS-triggered journeys. Journeys that send or react to SMS.

Push-triggered journeys. Journeys that send push notifications.

Multi-channel journeys. Combining channels in one journey.

Mobile campaign reporting. Reports for SMS and push performance.

14.5 Compliance: every topic explained

Consent. Permission to message, recorded with date and source.

Opt-in. The act and record of opting in.

Opt-out. STOP handling and unsubscribes.

Local messaging regulations. Rules in each country for SMS and push.

Message frequency. Limits to avoid annoying customers.

Subscriber preferences. Letting customers choose channels and topics.

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MODULE 15 HANDBOOK

Module 15: CloudPages and Landing Page Development

4 sections, 30 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

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Module 15: CloudPages and Landing Page Development

Level: Intermediate. CloudPages: landing pages, forms, data capture and secure processing.

Contents

1. 15.1 CloudPages Fundamentals
2. 15.2 CloudPages Development
3. 15.3 Form Processing
4. 15.4 Advanced CloudPages

Detailed lessons

Module 15

15.1 Building a registration page

WHAT IS IT?

> CloudPages are hosted pages built with HTML, CSS and AMPscript. A form posts data to a page that writes it to a data extension.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Lead capture and preference centres run on CloudPages.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Build the form with the required fields.
2. Read RequestParameter values on the page.
3. Write them to a data extension with UpsertDE.
4. Show a success or error message.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A newsletter sign-up writes the email to the Subscribers list.

COMMON ERRORS

Writing duplicate rows because the page never checks for an existing key.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you capture form data in CloudPages?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Build a newsletter sign-up page that writes to a data extension and handles duplicates.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- CloudPages documentation (Salesforce docs)

Module 15

15.2 Secure data capture and redirects

WHAT IS IT?

> Protect data by validating input, avoiding sensitive data in URLs and redirecting after success. Use RequestParameter and QueryParameter carefully.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Personal data in URLs ends up in logs and browser history.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Validate each field server-side.
2. Redirect after a successful post to avoid re-submits.
3. Do not put personal data in URLs.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> After submit, redirect to a thank-you page.

COMMON ERRORS

Accepting any input without checks.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you protect customer information on a form?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Add validation and a redirect to the registration page.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- AMPscript guide (Salesforce docs)

15.1 CloudPages Fundamentals: every topic explained

What is CloudPages?. Hosted pages in SFMC for forms, landing pages and microsites.

CloudPages architecture. Pages are published to URLs on SFMC servers, with AMPscript running on page load.

Landing pages. Single campaign pages.

Microsites. Groups of pages for a campaign.

Collection pages. Collections that organise pages and assets.

Published URLs. The public URL after publishing.

Page configuration. Settings such as page name, URL and SSL.

15.2 CloudPages Development: every topic explained

HTML. Page structure.

CSS. Page style.

AMPscript. Server-side logic and data access on the page.

Forms. Inputs for capturing data.

Data capture. Saving form input to data extensions.

Dynamic content. Content that changes by parameters or data.

Personalised landing pages. Pages tailored to the visitor using URL parameters or lookups.

15.3 Form Processing: every topic explained

Lead capture. Capturing prospect details.

Customer registration. Collecting customer sign-up data.

Form validation. Checking inputs before saving.

Data extension storage. Saving with UpsertDE or InsertDE.

Duplicate prevention. Upsert on a key to avoid duplicate rows.

Error messages. Clear messages when input is wrong.

Success messages. Confirmation after saving.

15.4 Advanced CloudPages: every topic explained

Personalised pages. Pages tailored using encrypted or parameterised links.

Secure data capture. HTTPS, validation and minimal personal data.

Dynamic URLs. Links that carry parameters to the page.

CloudPagesURL. Function that builds a link to a CloudPage with encrypted parameters.

RequestParameter. Reads a form or URL parameter.

Redirect. Function that sends the visitor to another URL.

QueryParameter. Reads a URL query parameter.

Server-side JavaScript fundamentals. SSJS for advanced page logic.

Secure form processing. Validate inputs, avoid personal data in URLs and protect keys.

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MODULE 16 HANDBOOK

Module 16: Marketing Cloud Personalization

3 sections, 17 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 16: Marketing Cloud Personalization

Level: Intermediate. Personalisation concepts and the current Marketing Cloud Personalization product, distinguished from legacy naming.

Contents

1. 16.1 Personalization Fundamentals
2. 16.2 Personalization Capabilities
3. 16.3 Personalization Strategy

Detailed lessons

Module 16

16.1 Personalisation concepts and product naming

WHAT IS IT?

> Personalisation shows each visitor the content that fits their profile and behaviour. Marketing Cloud Personalization is the current Salesforce product for real-time web and app personalisation; older material may call it Interaction Studio.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Clear product names avoid buying or building the wrong capability.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Confirm the product and its licence.
2. Map the data sources the product needs.
3. Define one measurable goal per experience.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A product page shows recommended items based on past browsing.

COMMON ERRORS

Using old Interaction Studio material for current features without checking.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How does personalisation differ from segmentation?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a one-page personalisation brief with one goal and its data sources.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce product pages (verify current naming)

16.1 Personalization Fundamentals: every topic explained

Personalisation concepts. Showing each person content that fits their profile and behaviour.

Customer profiles. Profiles combining attributes and behaviour.

Behavioural data. Clicks, views and purchases used for personalisation.

Real-time customer engagement. Reacting to what a visitor does now, not only past data.

Web personalisation. Changing website content per visitor.

Cross-channel personalisation. Using the same profile across web, email and app.

16.2 Personalization Capabilities: every topic explained

Visitor tracking. Collecting visitor behaviour with a web tag or SDK.

Customer identity. Linking anonymous visitors to known customers.

Segmentation. Groups based on behaviour and attributes.

Recommendations. Suggested products or content.

Personalised experiences. Content or offers that change per visitor.

Triggered interactions. Actions triggered by behaviour, such as a pop-up or email.

16.3 Personalization Strategy: every topic explained

Behaviour-based personalisation. Content chosen from recent behaviour.

Product recommendations. Suggesting products from browsing and purchases.

Web experiences. Personalised banners, sections and offers on the site.

Customer journey integration. Linking web personalisation with journeys.

Personalisation measurement. Measuring lift against a control group.

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MODULE 17 HANDBOOK

Module 17: Marketing Cloud Intelligence and Analytics

4 sections, 25 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

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Module 17: Marketing Cloud Intelligence and Analytics

Level: Intermediate. Campaign analytics, cross-channel reporting and the Intelligence product.

Contents

1. 17.1 Marketing Analytics
2. 17.2 Marketing Cloud Intelligence
3. 17.3 Performance Analysis
4. 17.4 Reporting

Detailed lessons

Module 17

17.1 Campaign analytics and attribution

WHAT IS IT?

> Analytics measure open, click, conversion and revenue by campaign and channel. Attribution assigns credit to channels. Intelligence connects data from many sources for cross-channel reporting.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Budget decisions depend on which channels create revenue.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define the revenue and conversion events.
2. Map campaign IDs consistently.
3. Build a dashboard with one page per question.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Email revenue per campaign: sum of orders attributed to each send within seven days.

COMMON ERRORS

Comparing channels with different attribution windows.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you measure campaign ROI?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Calculate ROI for three campaigns with stated assumptions.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Marketing Cloud Intelligence docs (verify current product)

17.1 Marketing Analytics: every topic explained

Marketing performance. Overall results of marketing activity.

Campaign analytics. Results per campaign.

Email analytics. Opens, clicks, bounces and conversions.

SMS analytics. SMS delivery and response.

Journey analytics. Entries, exits, goals and message results per journey.

Channel analytics. Comparing channels.

17.2 Marketing Cloud Intelligence: every topic explained

Platform overview. Cross-channel marketing analytics product (formerly Datorama), licensed separately.

Data connectors. Connectors to ad platforms, analytics and marketing tools.

Data ingestion. Bringing data into the platform.

Data harmonisation. Matching fields and names across sources.

Data modelling. Defining dimensions and measures.

Data visualisation. Charts and dashboards.

Marketing reporting. Regular reports for teams and leaders.

17.3 Performance Analysis: every topic explained

Campaign ROI. Revenue against cost per campaign.

Customer engagement. Engagement over time and by segment.

Conversion tracking. Tracking purchases or sign-ups linked to campaigns.

Attribution. Credit to channels and touchpoints.

Channel comparison. Comparing results across channels.

Marketing spend. Spend by channel and campaign.

Revenue analysis. Revenue by campaign, channel and segment.

17.4 Reporting: every topic explained

Standard reports. Built-in reports in SFMC.

Custom reports. Reports built with SQL and data extracts or analytics tools.

Performance dashboards. Dashboards of key measures.

Executive reporting. Short reports with decisions for leaders.

Campaign optimisation. Using reports to change audiences, content and timing.

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MODULE 18 HANDBOOK

Module 18: SFMC APIs and Integrations

6 sections, 53 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
Edition: November 2026. Practice labs marked "account" need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account. Other labs use sample files or paper.

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Module 18: SFMC APIs and Integrations

Level: Advanced. REST and SOAP APIs, installed packages, OAuth, and integration patterns with Salesforce and other systems.

Contents

1. 18.1 API Fundamentals
2. 18.2 Marketing Cloud APIs
3. 18.3 REST API Applications
4. 18.4 SOAP API
5. 18.5 Integrations
6. 18.6 API Development and Testing

Detailed lessons

Module 18

18.1 REST authentication with an installed package

WHAT IS IT?

> An installed package in SFMC gives an app a client ID and secret. The app requests an access token from the account's auth endpoint, then calls REST endpoints with the token. Token requests use your account subdomain.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Every integration starts with authentication; mistakes cause 401 errors and leaked credentials.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create an installed package with the required API permissions.
2. Copy the client ID, secret and subdomain (store them in a secrets manager).
3. Request a token and call one endpoint.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> POST to the token endpoint, then GET a data extension list with the bearer token.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
# Token request (replace the subdomain and credentials; never commit them)
curl -X POST "https://YOUR_SUBDOMAIN.auth.marketingcloudapis.com/v2/token" \
  -H "Content-Type: application/json" \
  -d '{"grant_type":"client_credentials","client_id":"YOUR_ID","client_secret":"YOUR_SECRET"}'
# The response contains access_token. Use it as: Authorization: Bearer <access_token>
```

COMMON ERRORS

Putting the client secret in front-end code.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain how OAuth works in an SFMC integration.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Authenticate with a sandbox account and list data extensions with Postman.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Marketing Cloud REST and SOAP API docs

Module 18

18.2 REST versus SOAP and common patterns

WHAT IS IT?

> REST uses JSON over HTTP and is the recommended approach for new work. SOAP uses XML and WSDL and remains available for some legacy operations. Patterns: create triggered sends, upsert contacts, read tracking data, manage assets.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Choosing the right API avoids rework; REST is simpler to test.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use REST for new integrations.
2. Check the docs for each operation's rate limits.
3. Log every request and response status.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Triggered send: POST with the subscriber, the email definition and personalisation attributes.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending bulk data one record at a time instead of using batch endpoints.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

REST versus SOAP: which would you use and why?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Describe a triggered-send integration with request, response and error handling.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

18.1 API Fundamentals: every topic explained

What is an API?. A defined way for one program to ask another for data or actions.

REST APIs. APIs that use URLs, HTTP methods and JSON.

HTTP methods. GET reads, POST creates, PUT and PATCH update, DELETE removes.

JSON. JavaScript Object Notation: text data with keys and values.

Endpoints. The URL for one API resource or action.

Request and response. The client sends a request; the server returns a response with a status code and body.

Authentication. Proving who is calling, usually with a token.

OAuth 2.0. A standard for getting access tokens without sharing passwords.

API keys. A key that identifies the calling app (SFMC mainly uses OAuth tokens).

Rate limits. Limits on calls per period; respect them with backoff.

Pagination. Getting large results in pages.

Webhooks. Calls sent to your URL when events happen.

18.2 Marketing Cloud APIs: every topic explained

Marketing Cloud Engagement API architecture. REST and SOAP APIs on account-specific endpoints, authenticated through installed packages.

Installed packages. Packages created in Setup that hold API integration components and credentials.

API integration components. The API integration in a package defines the client ID, secret and scopes.

Server-to-server integration. Server-to-server integration uses the client credentials grant, without a user login.

REST API. JSON API for most modern operations.

SOAP API. XML API with WSDL for many legacy and bulk operations.

Authentication. Get a token from the auth endpoint with the package credentials.

Access tokens. Tokens expire; request a new one before expiry.

Scopes. Permissions requested for the token, such as data extension read or email send.

API permissions. Choose the minimum permissions in the package.

18.3 REST API Applications: every topic explained

Creating data extensions. Create data extensions through the API.

Retrieving data. Read rows from data extensions.

Managing assets. Create and update Content Builder assets.

Creating email sends. Start sends through the API.

Triggered sends. Send transactional or triggered messages through the API.

Journey interactions where supported. Fire API events that inject contacts into journeys, where configured.

Subscriber management. Update subscriber status and attributes.

Contact management. Create and update contacts.

18.4 SOAP API: every topic explained

SOAP fundamentals. XML messages in an envelope with a header and body.

WSDL. The service description file listing operations and objects.

Objects. Objects such as DataExtension, Subscriber and Send.

Retrieve operations. Retrieve requests with filters and properties.

Create operations. Create requests to add objects.

Update operations. Update requests to change objects.

Delete operations. Delete requests to remove objects.

SOAP request structure. Envelope, header with token, body with the request object.

18.5 Integrations: every topic explained

Salesforce Sales Cloud. Marketing Cloud Connect links Sales Cloud data and activities.

Salesforce Service Cloud. Service Cloud cases and contacts used in journeys.

Salesforce CRM. Synchronised CRM objects for segmentation and journeys.

External CRM systems. Other CRMs connect through APIs or middleware.

E-commerce platforms. Orders and carts from commerce systems for journeys.

Payment systems. Payment events such as failures trigger messages.

Web applications. Apps call the API to trigger messages or update data.

External databases. Data exchanged by files, APIs or integration tools.

18.6 API Development and Testing: every topic explained

Postman. A tool to build and test API requests.

Authentication testing. Check token requests and expiry handling.

Request testing. Send sample requests with test data.

Response validation. Check status codes and response bodies.

Error handling. Handle 4xx and 5xx responses with clear actions.

Logging. Log requests and responses without secrets.

API security. Protect credentials, use HTTPS and least privilege.

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MODULE 19 HANDBOOK

Module 19: Salesforce Data Cloud and Marketing Cloud Integration

4 sections, 24 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
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Module 19: Salesforce Data Cloud and Marketing Cloud Integration

Level: Advanced. Data Cloud concepts and how unified profiles reach Marketing Cloud for activation.

Contents

1. 19.1 Data Cloud Fundamentals
2. 19.2 Data Integration
3. 19.3 Marketing Activation
4. 19.4 Enterprise Use Cases

Detailed lessons

Module 19

19.1 Data Cloud concepts

WHAT IS IT?

> Data Cloud ingests data from many sources, resolves identities into unified profiles, and makes segments and calculated insights available for activation, including to Marketing Cloud. Naming and licensing change; check current Salesforce documentation.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Enterprise Customer 360 projects depend on unified profiles.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Map sources to data streams.
2. Define identity resolution rules.
3. Build a segment and activate it to Marketing Cloud.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Web events and CRM records unified into one profile; the segment 'recent buyers' activates to a journey.

COMMON ERRORS

Assuming Data Cloud is included with Marketing Cloud Engagement.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is identity resolution?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Draw the data flow from three sources to one activated segment.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Data Cloud documentation (verify)

19.1 Data Cloud Fundamentals: every topic explained

What is Salesforce Data Cloud?. Salesforce's customer data platform for unifying and activating customer data.

Data Cloud architecture. Ingestion, harmonisation, identity resolution, insights and activation layers.

Data streams. Sources of data such as CRM, web, files and apps.

Data model objects. Harmonised standard objects data is mapped to.

Data lake objects. Raw ingested data objects.

Identity resolution. Rules that match records to the same person.

Unified customer profiles. One profile per person built from many sources.

19.2 Data Integration: every topic explained

Data ingestion. Bringing data into Data Cloud.

Data transformation. Cleaning and shaping data.

Data mapping. Mapping source fields to data model objects.

Identity resolution. Matching and reconciliation rules.

Calculated insights. Metrics computed on profiles, such as lifetime value.

Segmentation. Building segments from profiles.

Activation. Sending segments to Marketing Cloud and other targets.

19.3 Marketing Activation: every topic explained

Audience activation. Making a segment available in a marketing tool.

Customer segmentation. Grouping profiles for targeting.

Personalised engagement. Messages using unified data.

Cross-channel activation. Activating to email, SMS, ads and web.

Marketing Cloud integration. Using activated segments in Marketing Cloud journeys.

19.4 Enterprise Use Cases: every topic explained

Unified customer view. One view of each customer across systems.

Customer 360. Salesforce's idea of a complete customer view.

Real-time segmentation. Segments that update quickly as data arrives.

Personalised campaigns. Campaigns using unified data.

Customer lifecycle activation. Lifecycle journeys driven by unified profiles.

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MODULE 20 HANDBOOK

Module 20: Advanced Marketing Automation and Personalisation

4 sections, 23 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 20: Advanced Marketing Automation and Personalisation

Level: Advanced. Event-driven and lifecycle automation, advanced segmentation and optimisation.

Contents

1. 20.1 Advanced Automation Strategy
2. 20.2 Advanced Segmentation
3. 20.3 Advanced Personalisation
4. 20.4 Marketing Optimisation

Detailed lessons

Module 20

20.1 Lifecycle automation and optimisation

WHAT IS IT?

> Lifecycle automation runs journeys on events (sign-up, purchase, lapse). Optimisation tests variants, frequency and send times, measuring the results with control groups.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Automated lifecycle programmes compound revenue and retention.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Define the lifecycle events.
2. Create a control group to measure lift.
3. Test one variable at a time.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Win-back journey with a 10% holdout to measure incremental revenue.

COMMON ERRORS

Declaring success without a control group.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you measure a journey's incremental impact?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a win-back test with a holdout and a success metric.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

20.1 Advanced Automation Strategy: every topic explained

Event-driven marketing. Messages triggered by events, not batch schedules.

Behavioural automation. Automation driven by behaviour.

Lifecycle automation. Programmes for each lifecycle stage.

Cross-channel automation. Coordinated email, SMS, push and web.

Triggered campaigns. Campaigns sent when an event happens.

Real-time engagement. Responding in near real time.

20.2 Advanced Segmentation: every topic explained

Behavioural segmentation. By behaviour such as browsing and engagement.

Demographic segmentation. By age, location and other attributes.

Transactional segmentation. By purchases and spend.

Predictive segmentation. By predicted behaviour such as churn risk.

Engagement-based segmentation. By recent engagement level.

Dynamic audience management. Audiences that update automatically.

20.3 Advanced Personalisation: every topic explained

Dynamic recommendations. Recommendations that change by data.

Conditional personalisation. Content variants by rules.

Customer preferences. Using stated preferences.

Personalised journeys. Journeys that adapt per person.

Content decisioning. Choosing the best content per person by rules or models.

20.4 Marketing Optimisation: every topic explained

A/B testing. Test variants to find what works.

Experiment design. Hypothesis, control group, sample size and duration.

Send-time optimisation. Sending at each person's best time where licensed.

Frequency management. Limiting how often a person receives messages.

Engagement optimisation. Improving opens and clicks.

Conversion optimisation. Improving the share who complete the goal.

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MODULE 21 HANDBOOK

Module 21: SFMC Security, Privacy and Deliverability

5 sections, 38 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 21: SFMC Security, Privacy and Deliverability

Level: Advanced. Access control, consent, deliverability and compliance with data protection laws.

Contents

1. 21.1 Security
2. 21.2 Privacy
3. 21.3 Deliverability
4. 21.4 Compliance
5. 21.5 Governance

Detailed lessons

Module 21

21.1 Security and access

WHAT IS IT?

> Access control uses roles, permission sets and business-unit access. API credentials need least privilege and rotation. Audit trails record changes.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Breaches usually come from over-broad access or leaked credentials.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Review roles every quarter.
2. Rotate API secrets.
3. Keep audit logs on.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A campaign manager cannot export the full customer table.

COMMON ERRORS

Sharing one admin login between people.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you control access in an SFMC account?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write an access review checklist.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 21

21.2 Privacy and compliance

WHAT IS IT?

> GDPR (EU) and India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act set rules for consent, minimisation, access and deletion. CAN-SPAM (US) and CASL (Canada) set email rules. Check the rules that apply to each audience.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Non-compliance leads to fines and blocked sends.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Record consent and its source.
2. Honour unsubscribes immediately.
3. Keep data only as long as needed.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A consent flag in the contact model controls which journeys a person may enter.

COMMON ERRORS

Treating consent as one checkbox for every channel.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do GDPR and DPDP affect marketing data?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a consent model for email and SMS.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- GDPR text (official EU)
- MeitY: DPDP framework (official)

21.1 Security: every topic explained

Authentication. Verifying users and systems at login and in APIs.

Authorisation. Deciding what each user or system may do.

User permissions. Rights given to users.

Role management. Assigning roles carefully.

Business unit access. Limiting users to the business units they need.

API security. Least-privilege packages and secret rotation.

Data access. Controlling export and access to personal data.

21.2 Privacy: every topic explained

Customer consent. Recording and honouring consent.

Preference management. Letting people choose channels and topics.

Subscription management. Managing list and publication membership.

Data retention. Keeping data only as long as needed.

Data deletion. Deleting data on request.

Privacy-by-design. Designing privacy into every flow.

Data minimisation. Collecting only what is needed.

21.3 Deliverability: every topic explained

Sender reputation. Trust mailbox providers place in your sending.

IP reputation. Reputation of your sending IPs.

Domain authentication. SPF, DKIM and DMARC for your domains.

SPF. Authorised sending servers.

DKIM. Message signature.

DMARC. Policy and reports.

Bounce management. Processing bounces and removing bad addresses.

Complaint management. Keeping complaints very low.

Spam traps. Addresses used to catch spammers; avoid them with good list practice.

Suppression management. Applying suppression lists before sends.

Inbox placement. Landing in the inbox.

21.4 Compliance: every topic explained

GDPR fundamentals. EU rules for personal data.

India's Digital Personal Data Protection framework. India's Digital Personal Data Protection Act and rules.

CAN-SPAM. US commercial email law.

CASL. Canada's anti-spam law, requiring consent.

TCPA and applicable messaging requirements. US rules for calls and texts.

Consent and unsubscribe obligations. Duties to get consent and honour opt-outs.

Industry-specific requirements. Extra rules in finance, health and other sectors.

21.5 Governance: every topic explained

Data governance. Ownership and rules for data.

Asset governance. Control over content and templates.

Access governance. Control over who has access.

Campaign approval. Review and approval before sends.

Audit trails. Records of changes and actions.

Operational controls. Checks and procedures for daily operations.

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MODULE 22 HANDBOOK

Module 22: SFMC Testing, Troubleshooting and Performance

4 sections, 33 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

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Module 22: SFMC Testing, Troubleshooting and Performance

Level: Advanced. Testing campaigns and integrations, troubleshooting failures and tuning performance.

Contents

1. 22.1 SFMC Testing
2. 22.2 Troubleshooting
3. 22.3 Performance Optimisation
4. 22.4 Production Support

Detailed lessons

Module 22

22.1 Testing and troubleshooting

WHAT IS IT?

> Test email previews, personalisation, links, journeys with test contacts, automations on sample data, SQL on small populations and APIs with sandbox calls. Troubleshooting follows the error, the logs and recent changes.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Most production incidents are preventable with a test plan.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Send tests to seed addresses.
2. Check each personalisation with a missing value.
3. Run SQL on a sample before a full run.
4. Keep a runbook.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A seed-list test shows a broken personalisation before the real send.

COMMON ERRORS

Testing only with one perfect record.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you investigate a failed email send?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Create a test plan for a welcome email and journey.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

22.1 SFMC Testing: every topic explained

Email testing. Preview, test sends and link checks.

Personalisation testing. Checking personalisation with varied data.

Journey testing. Testing journeys with test contacts.

Automation testing. Running automations on test data.

SQL query testing. Testing queries on small data.

API testing. Testing API calls in a sandbox.

CloudPages testing. Testing forms and pages.

Mobile messaging testing. Testing SMS and push.

22.2 Troubleshooting: every topic explained

Email send failures. Check the send log, audience, classification and content errors.

Subscriber errors. Check status, keys and data.

Data extension errors. Check field types, keys and nullable fields.

SQL errors. Check syntax, field names and supported functions.

Journey entry problems. Check the entry source, filters, re-entry and activation.

Automation failures. Check run history and the failed activity.

API errors. Check status codes, tokens and request bodies.

AMPscript errors. Check variable names, lookups and missing data.

CloudPages errors. Check page code, parameters and data writes.

Deliverability issues. Check authentication, bounces and complaints.

22.3 Performance Optimisation: every topic explained

SQL query optimisation. Select needed fields, filter early and avoid unnecessary joins.

Data extension optimisation. Index-friendly keys and lean tables.

Automation scheduling. Avoid peak times and long chains.

Journey performance. Keep journeys simple and avoid unnecessary splits.

Asset organisation. Clean folders and naming.

API efficiency. Batch calls and respect limits.

Data volume management. Archive old data and set retention.

22.4 Production Support: every topic explained

Incident management. Detect, triage, fix and communicate incidents.

Root-cause analysis. Find the underlying cause.

Error logs. Reading error logs and run history.

Monitoring. Watching dashboards and alerts.

Escalation. Bringing in the right people.

Change management. Controlled changes with approval.

Release validation. Checks after each release.

Post-incident reporting. A short report on what happened and what will change.

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MODULE 23 HANDBOOK

Module 23: SFMC Architecture and Enterprise Implementation

5 sections, 32 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

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Module 23: SFMC Architecture and Enterprise Implementation

Level: Advanced. Architecture decisions for multi-business-unit programmes and how to document them.

Contents

1. 23.1 Solution Architecture
2. 23.2 Enterprise Implementation
3. 23.3 Multi-Business-Unit Architecture
4. 23.4 Technical Documentation
5. 23.5 Deployment and Change Management

Detailed lessons

Module 23

23.1 Multi-business-unit architecture

WHAT IS IT?

> Decide what is shared at parent level (footers, compliance text, reference data) and what is isolated per business unit (sender, subscribers, data). Document each decision.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Architecture choices decide governance, cost and how easily brands can change.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Write requirements (functional and non-functional).
2. Draw the business unit and data diagram.
3. Record decisions as ADRs.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Shared reference data at parent; brand subscribers isolated in child business units.

COMMON ERRORS

Sharing subscriber data across brands without a legal basis.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Design a multi-business-unit SFMC solution.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a one-page architecture for two brands with one shared footer library.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- C4 model (diagrams)

23.1 Solution Architecture: every topic explained

SFMC architecture. How SFMC is set up for a customer.

Enterprise architecture. How SFMC fits with CRM, data and other systems.

Business unit strategy. Plan for business units.

Data architecture. Plan for data and keys.

Integration architecture. Plan for APIs, files and connectors.

Security architecture. Plan for access and data protection.

23.2 Enterprise Implementation: every topic explained

Requirement discovery. Interviews and workshops to learn needs.

Business process mapping. Mapping current processes.

Technical requirements. Systems, data and performance needs.

Functional requirements. What the solution must do.

Non-functional requirements. Security, performance and availability needs.

Solution design. The design document.

Implementation planning. Plan, phases and resources.

23.3 Multi-Business-Unit Architecture: every topic explained

Parent-child business units. Parent and child units and what is shared.

Shared data extensions. Shared tables across units.

Shared assets. Shared content across units.

Business unit governance. Rules for each unit.

Data isolation. Keeping each unit's data separate.

Centralised versus decentralised architecture. Central control versus local teams.

23.4 Technical Documentation: every topic explained

Architecture diagrams. Diagrams of components.

Data flow diagrams. Diagrams of data movement.

Integration specifications. Specs for each integration.

Data mapping documents. Field-level mapping between systems.

Solution design documents. The full design document.

Technical runbooks. Step-by-step operational guides.

23.5 Deployment and Change Management: every topic explained

Development and testing. Build and test in a test business unit or sandbox.

UAT. User acceptance testing with the business.

Production release. Planned release to production.

Asset migration. Moving assets between business units or accounts with packages or tools.

Configuration management. Recording configuration.

Release validation. Checking after release.

Rollback planning. Plan to undo a release.

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MODULE 24 HANDBOOK

Module 24: AI in Marketing Cloud and Intelligent Automation

6 sections, 40 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 24: AI in Marketing Cloud and Intelligent Automation

Level: Advanced. AI features in marketing automation, with product names and licences checked on official pages, and AI integration with APIs.

Contents

1. 24.1 AI Fundamentals for Marketing
2. 24.2 Salesforce AI Capabilities
3. 24.3 Generative AI for Marketing
4. 24.4 AI-Powered Marketing Analytics
5. 24.5 AI Agents for Marketing Operations
6. 24.6 AI Integrations

Detailed lessons

Module 24

24.1 AI for campaigns and analytics

WHAT IS IT?

> AI can draft subject lines and copy, suggest segments, predict churn and recommend next actions. Salesforce AI capabilities are offered under specific product and licence names; verify before promising them.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> AI speeds up content work but needs human approval and tested outputs.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use AI to draft, a human to approve.
2. Test generated copy for compliance and brand rules.
3. Measure lift against the control group.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> AI drafts three subject lines; the team tests two with a 10% split.

COMMON ERRORS

Publishing AI copy without review.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you use AI safely in a campaign workflow?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design an AI copy workflow with human approval steps.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce AI overview (verify)

Module 24

24.2 Integrating an external AI model

WHAT IS IT?

> An integration sends campaign data to an AI model API and writes the result back to a data extension. Keep personal data minimal and never send secrets to a model.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> External models are useful when a feature is not in the SFMC licence.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Send only the fields the model needs.
2. Store the output in a review table.
3. Log model version and cost.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A monthly churn score is written to a data extension, then used in a journey split.

COMMON ERRORS

Sending full customer records to a third-party model.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you add an AI score to a journey safely?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design the data flow for a churn-score integration with privacy controls.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Anthropic: API docs
- OpenAI: API docs

24.1 AI Fundamentals for Marketing: every topic explained

Artificial Intelligence. Systems that perform tasks needing human-like judgement.

Machine Learning. Models that learn from data.

Generative AI. Models that create text, images and more.

Predictive analytics. Predicting future behaviour.

Personalisation. Tailoring content to each person.

Intelligent automation. Automation with AI decisions inside.

24.2 Salesforce AI Capabilities: every topic explained

Einstein capabilities. Salesforce Einstein AI features across products; check which are licensed in your account.

Einstein engagement-related capabilities. Engagement scoring, send-time optimisation and similar features where licensed.

Predictive insights. Predicted likelihoods such as engagement.

Recommendations. Product and content suggestions.

AI-assisted marketing. AI help in content and segmentation.

Agentforce concepts. Salesforce's AI agent platform; check current product scope.

Salesforce AI ecosystem. Salesforce AI products and partners.

24.3 Generative AI for Marketing: every topic explained

AI email content generation. Drafting email content with AI.

Subject-line generation. Generating subject line options.

Personalised content. Variants per segment.

Campaign planning. AI help with campaign plans.

Marketing copy. Drafting copy for review.

Content optimisation. Improving copy based on results.

Customer segmentation support. Suggesting segments to test.

24.4 AI-Powered Marketing Analytics: every topic explained

Customer behaviour analysis. Patterns in behaviour.

Churn prediction. Predicting who will leave.

Customer lifetime value. Predicting customer value.

Propensity modelling. Likelihood to buy or respond.

Next-best-action concepts. Choosing the next best action per customer.

Campaign recommendations. Suggesting campaigns from data.

24.5 AI Agents for Marketing Operations: every topic explained

Marketing assistant agents. Agents that help marketers draft and plan.

Customer support agents. Agents that answer customer questions.

Campaign operations agents. Agents that prepare and check campaign tasks.

Data analysis agents. Agents that analyse results.

Human approvals. Humans approve sends and changes.

Workflow automation. Agents trigger workflows within limits.

CRM integration. Agents read and update CRM data with permissions.

24.6 AI Integrations: every topic explained

OpenAI APIs. OpenAI models via API.

Claude APIs. Anthropic Claude models via API.

Gemini APIs. Google Gemini models via API.

Salesforce APIs. Salesforce platform APIs.

Marketing Cloud integration. Writing AI outputs back to SFMC data extensions.

External data integration. Joining external data with AI results.

AI workflow automation. Automating AI steps with approvals and logs.

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MODULE 25 HANDBOOK

Module 25: Practical Labs and Real-World Scenarios

1 sections, 1 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
Edition: November 2026. Practice labs marked "account" need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account. Other labs use sample files or paper.

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Module 25: Practical Labs and Real-World Scenarios

Level: All levels. Twenty step-by-step labs. Some need a provisioned SFMC account; others are simulated or can be done on paper.

Contents

1. 25.1 Practical labs

Detailed lessons

Module 25

25.1 How to use the labs

WHAT IS IT?

> Each lab lists the objective, scenario, prerequisites, tools, dataset, steps, code, expected output, validation, common errors and assessment. Labs marked 'account' need a provisioned Marketing Cloud account; labs marked 'simulated' can be done with sample files and paper.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Practice on real data builds the skill employers test for.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Check the lab's requirement tag first.
2. Work in a sandbox or test business unit.
3. Keep a log of errors and fixes.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Lab 4: import and clean customer records (account required).

COMMON ERRORS

Practising in production.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you practise SFMC without a paid account?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Pick one simulated lab and complete it on sample files.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

25.1 Practical labs: every topic explained

Lab 1 to Lab 20 (see the Labs list in the handbook). Twenty labs from account setup to AI-assisted automation. Labs marked account need a provisioned SFMC account; others are simulated.

Lab list

Lab	Title	Requirement
Lab 1	Create a basic SFMC account and understand the environment	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 2	Design an enterprise business unit structure	Simulated or paper practice
Lab 3	Create a customer data extension	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 4	Import and clean customer records	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 5	Write SQL segmentation queries	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 6	Create an email template	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 7	Build a personalised email using AMPscript	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 8	Create a dynamic content email	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 9	Build a welcome journey	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 10	Create an abandoned cart journey	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 11	Build a customer retention automation	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 12	Create a scheduled SQL automation	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 13	Build a CloudPage registration form	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 14	Integrate SFMC using REST APIs	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 15	Create an API-triggered email	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 16	Build an SMS customer notification	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 17	Create a marketing performance dashboard	Simulated or paper practice
Lab 18	Integrate Salesforce CRM data	Needs a provisioned SFMC account
Lab 19	Design a Customer 360 activation workflow	Simulated or paper practice
Lab 20	Develop an AI-assisted marketing automation workflow	Simulated or paper practice

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MODULE 26 HANDBOOK

Module 26: Capstone Projects and Portfolio

1 sections, 8 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in
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Module 26: Capstone Projects and Portfolio

Level: Advanced. Eight capstone projects with requirements, architecture, code, testing and demo evidence.

Contents

1. 26.1 Capstone projects

Detailed lessons

Module 26

26.1 Portfolio standard

WHAT IS IT?

> Each project includes business problem, users, scope, requirements, architecture, data model, data flow, steps, SQL and AMPscript code, testing, evidence, KPIs, impact, limitations, future work, documentation and a demo video.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A portfolio with evidence gets interviews; a list of tools does not.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Write the business problem first.
2. Build and test each part.
3. Record a 3-minute demo.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Project 3: abandoned cart automation with SQL segments and a multi-channel follow-up.

COMMON ERRORS

Showing screenshots with no explanation.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does a strong SFMC portfolio project include?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Choose one of the eight projects and write its requirements.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

26.1 Capstone projects: every topic explained

Project 1: End-to-end email marketing automation. Segmentation, email, AMPscript, execution and reporting end to end.

Project 2: Customer onboarding journey. Journey with email, SMS and splits for new customers.

Project 3: E-commerce abandoned cart automation. Cart data, SQL, journey entry and multi-channel follow-up.

Project 4: Customer retention and re-engagement. Engagement analysis with data views, segments and journeys.

Project 5: Enterprise Customer 360. CRM data, contact model and Data Cloud design for unified profiles.

Project 6: API-driven marketing automation. Authentication, external system integration and triggered messages.

Project 7: Advanced personalisation engine. Behaviour-based dynamic content and journeys.

Project 8: AI-powered marketing automation platform. AI integration with approvals, reporting, security and monitoring.

Project briefs

Project 1: End-to-end email marketing automation

Customer data, segmentation, email design, AMPscript, campaign execution and performance reporting.

Project 2: Customer onboarding journey

Customer data, Journey Builder, email, SMS, decision splits and performance tracking.

Project 3: E-commerce abandoned cart automation

Transactional data, SQL segmentation, journey entry, personalised recommendations and multi-channel follow-up.

Project 4: Customer retention and re-engagement

Engagement analysis with SQL and data views, segmentation, journey automation and KPI measurement.

Project 5: Enterprise Customer 360

CRM data, contact model, data extensions, integration, Data Cloud architecture and unified profiles.

Project 6: API-driven marketing automation

API architecture, authentication, external system integration, triggered messaging and error handling.

Project 7: Advanced personalisation engine

Customer behaviour, AMPscript, dynamic content, segmentation and personalised journeys.

Project 8: AI-powered marketing automation platform

SFMC data, AI integration, segmentation, campaign recommendations, automated reporting, human approval, security and monitoring.

Every project must include

1. Business problem
2. Target users
3. Project scope
4. Functional requirements

5. Non-functional requirements
6. Solution architecture
7. Data model
8. Data flow diagram
9. Technology stack
10. Implementation steps
11. SQL and AMPscript code where applicable
12. Testing
13. Screenshots or demo evidence
14. KPIs
15. Business impact
16. Limitations
17. Future enhancements
18. Technical documentation
19. Portfolio presentation
20. Demo video

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MODULE 27 HANDBOOK

Module 27: SFMC Interview Preparation and Career Readiness

2 sections, 14 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 27: SFMC Interview Preparation and Career Readiness

Level: All levels. Technical, scenario and behavioural interviews for SFMC roles, with a question bank and practice plan.

Contents

1. 27.1 Career pathways
2. 27.2 Technical, scenario and behavioural interviews

Detailed lessons

Module 27

27.1 Interview readiness

WHAT IS IT?

> Interviews test SQL, AMPscript, journeys, automations, APIs, architecture and troubleshooting. Practise by explaining your own projects with results.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Hiring managers look for evidence of production work and clear reasoning.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Practise 20 SQL questions and 10 AMPscript exercises.
2. Prepare two project stories with results.
3. Do two mock interviews a week.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Scenario: a high bounce rate. Investigate by list source, hard versus soft bounce, domain, timing and sender reputation.

COMMON ERRORS

Answering without a method.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

A campaign has a high bounce rate. How do you investigate?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Answer the eight scenario questions out loud and record yourself.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Interview bank: see the Interview Preparation Handbook

27.1 Career pathways: every topic explained

SFMC Email Marketing Specialist. Builds and sends email campaigns.

SFMC Campaign Specialist. Plans and runs campaigns end to end.

SFMC Developer. Writes SQL, AMPscript, SSJS and integrations.

SFMC Consultant. Advises on solutions and implements them.

SFMC Technical Consultant. Bridges business and technical design.

SFMC Administrator. Manages users, setup and governance.

SFMC Automation Specialist. Builds journeys and automations.

SFMC Solution Architect. Designs enterprise SFMC solutions.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud Data Specialist. Owns data models and data quality.

Marketing Automation Architect. Designs marketing automation across platforms.

27.2 Technical, scenario and behavioural interviews: every topic explained

Question bank by area (see the interview handbook). Questions grouped by area in the interview handbook.

Eight scenario-based interviews. Business scenarios with structured answers.

Behavioural interview questions. Behavioural questions answered with STAR.

Model answers (next batch). Model answers are being added in the next batch.

SFMC fundamentals

1. What is SFMC?
2. Explain SFMC architecture.
3. What is a MID?
4. What is a business unit?
5. Explain contact key versus subscriber key.

Data extensions

1. What is a sendable data extension?
2. What is a primary key?
3. Explain data retention.
4. What is a shared data extension?

SQL

1. Explain SQL joins.
2. Write a query to identify inactive subscribers.
3. Explain ROW_NUMBER.
4. Explain data views.
5. How would you optimise a query?

Email Studio

1. Explain subscriber statuses.
2. What are send classifications?
3. Explain triggered sends.
4. What is suppression management?

AMPscript

1. What is AMPscript?
2. Explain Lookup and LookupRows.
3. Explain AttributeValue.
4. Write a personalised email.
5. How do you troubleshoot AMPscript errors?

Journey Builder

1. Explain entry sources.
2. What is a Decision Split?
3. What is an Engagement Split?
4. Explain journey re-entry.
5. How do you troubleshoot journey entry failures?

Automation Studio

1. Explain SQL Query Activity.
2. What is a File Transfer Activity?
3. How do you create a scheduled automation?
4. How do you troubleshoot automation failures?

CloudPages

1. What are CloudPages?
2. Explain RequestParameter.
3. How do you capture form data?
4. How do you protect customer information?

APIs

1. Explain REST versus SOAP.
2. What is OAuth 2.0?
3. What are installed packages?
4. How do you integrate an external system?

Architecture

1. Design a multi-business-unit SFMC solution.
2. Explain customer data architecture.
3. How do you integrate Sales Cloud and SFMC?
4. How would you design an enterprise marketing automation platform?

AI

1. How can AI improve marketing automation?
2. Explain predictive personalisation.
3. How can an AI assistant integrate with SFMC?
4. How do you ensure customer data security?

Scenarios

1. A campaign has a high bounce rate. How do you investigate?
2. An email send failed. What steps would you take?
3. A journey is not accepting new contacts. How do you troubleshoot?
4. A customer receives duplicate emails. How would you identify the root cause?
5. A SQL query is returning duplicate records. How would you fix it?
6. An automation failed during a production run. How would you handle it?
7. A business needs customer data from multiple systems. How would you design the integration?
8. A customer wants personalised communications across email and SMS. How would you build the journey?

Behavioural

1. Tell me about yourself.
2. Describe an SFMC implementation.
3. Explain a difficult production issue.
4. Describe a technical problem you solved.
5. How do you handle stakeholders?
6. How do you manage urgent campaign requests?
7. Explain your approach to testing and quality.

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MODULE 28 HANDBOOK

Module 28: Certification Preparation and Learning Roadmap

2 sections, 4 topics explained, plus the detailed lessons, examples, exercises and official links.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 28: Certification Preparation and Learning Roadmap

Level: All levels. How to prepare for Salesforce certifications and a realistic 12-month plan. Certification names must be checked on Trailhead before you register.

Contents

1. 28.1 Certification preparation
2. 28.2 Learning roadmap

Detailed lessons

Module 28

28.1 Certifications and the roadmap

WHAT IS IT?

> Salesforce certifications change over time. Check the official Trailhead credentials catalogue for active names, prerequisites, exam objectives and weighting. The roadmap in this academy gives a 12-month study plan.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A current, recognised certification helps screening, but experience matters more.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Open the official credentials list on Trailhead and note active names.
2. Read the exam guide for the one you choose.
3. Follow the 12-month roadmap.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Plan: months 1 to 3 fundamentals; months 4 to 8 applied labs; months 9 to 12 projects and exam.

COMMON ERRORS

Registering before the exam guide is read.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you prepare for an SFMC certification?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write your own 12-month plan using the template.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Trailhead credentials (official)

28.1 Certification preparation: every topic explained

Verify active certifications on the official Trailhead credentials list. Check the Trailhead credentials catalogue for the current names before planning.

Exam objectives for each active certification (next batch). Exam guides list objectives and weightings; read them on Trailhead.

Practice questions (next batch). Practice with official Trailhead resources and practice tests.

28.2 Learning roadmap: every topic explained

Stage 1 to Stage 9 (see the 12-month roadmap PDF). A nine-stage plan across 12 months; see the roadmap PDF and tracker.

12-month roadmap

Stage	Topics	Study time	Milestone	Assessment
Stage 1 · Months 1 to 2	CRM and marketing fundamentals, Salesforce ecosystem, SFMC basics (Modules 1 to 3)	About 8 hours a week	Lifecycle map, metrics calculations, business unit design	Explain the lifecycle and metrics in an interview-style answer
Stage 2 · Months 3 to 4	Contacts, data architecture, data extensions, import and cleaning (Modules 4 and 5)	About 10 hours a week	Customer data extension with keys and a clean import	Import a file with planted duplicates and fix it
Stage 3 · Months 5 to 6	SQL for SFMC, HTML and CSS, JavaScript basics, AMPscript (Modules 6, 9 and 10)	About 12 hours a week	Ten SQL queries, a responsive email, ten AMPscript personalisations	Code review and a timed SQL test
Stage 4 · Months 7 to 8	Email Studio, Content Builder, Journey Builder, Automation Studio (Modules 7, 8, 11 and 12)	About 12 hours a week	Welcome journey, abandoned cart journey, scheduled automation	Journey and automation walkthrough
Stage 5 · Months 9 to 10	CloudPages, Mobile Studio, personalisation, analytics, APIs and integrations (Modules 13 to 18)	About 12 hours a week	CloudPage form, REST integration, API-triggered email	API demo with Postman and error handling
Stage 6 · Month 11	Data Cloud, advanced automation, security, deliverability, testing and architecture (Modules 19 to 23)	About 10 hours a week	Architecture document and a troubleshooting report	Architecture presentation and scenario answers
Stage 7 · Month 12	AI in marketing, capstone projects, portfolio, interviews and certification planning (Modules 24, 26 to 28)	About 15 hours a week	Two capstone projects published with demo videos	Three mock interviews and a certification plan

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HANDBOOK 2

SQL for Salesforce Marketing Cloud

SQL fundamentals, joins, aggregates, data views and the code examples explained line by line.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

Varun Kumar · SkillNavora · skillnavora.in

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Module 6: SQL for Salesforce Marketing Cloud

Level: Beginner to intermediate. SQL in SFMC: query activities, the supported syntax, aggregation, joins, data views and common audience queries.

Module 6

6.1 SQL fundamentals in SFMC

WHAT IS IT?

> SFMC SQL runs in Query Activities inside Automation Studio. It uses a T-SQL style syntax with some restrictions compared with SQL Server. Core clauses: SELECT, FROM, WHERE, GROUP BY, HAVING, ORDER BY.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Audiences, reports and suppression lists are almost always built with SQL in SFMC.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Write the query in the Query Activity.
2. Set a target data extension and an update option (overwrite or append).
3. Run the activity, then check the row count in the target.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Select active customers from the Customers data extension into an Audience data extension.

COMMON ERRORS

Writing a query that works in SQL Server but is not supported in SFMC. Always test in the Query Activity.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is a Query Activity?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a query that selects customers in one city and counts them.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- SFMC SQL reference (Salesforce docs)

6.2 Aggregation, joins and CTEs

WHAT IS IT?

> Aggregates (COUNT, SUM, AVG, MIN, MAX) with GROUP BY summarise data. JOIN combines data extensions and system data views. Common table expressions (WITH) name steps. Check the official SQL restrictions for the exact features your account supports.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Joins and aggregates produce segments and reports; a wrong join silently changes audience size.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use INNER JOIN when both sides must match.
2. Use LEFT JOIN to keep all customers and show missing orders as NULL.
3. Count distinct customers, not rows, when a customer has many orders.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Customers with no order in 90 days: LEFT JOIN orders and keep rows where the order is NULL.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
-- Customers with no order in the last 90 days
SELECT c.SubscriberKey, c.EmailAddress
FROM Customers c
LEFT JOIN Orders o
  ON o.SubscriberKey = c.SubscriberKey
  AND o.OrderDate ⩾ DATEADD(day, -90, GETDATE())
WHERE o.OrderID IS NULL;
-- Line by line: LEFT JOIN keeps every customer; the date condition is inside the join so only
recent orders match;
-- WHERE o.OrderID IS NULL keeps customers with no matching recent order.
```

COMMON ERRORS

Counting rows where you need distinct customers.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain the difference between INNER JOIN and LEFT JOIN.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the 90-day inactivity query and explain each line.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- SFMC SQL reference (Salesforce docs)

Module 6

6.3 SFMC data views

WHAT IS IT?

> System data views hold sends, opens, clicks, bounces, unsubscribes, jobs, journey activity and SMS tracking. Examples: _Subscribers, _Sent, _Open, _Click, _Bounce, _Unsubscribe, _Job, _Journey, _JourneyActivity, _SMSMessageTracking, _Complaint, _BusinessUnitUnsubscribes. Each has its own keys and retention limit.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Engagement analysis and suppression depend on these views. Retention limits mean old data may be gone, so keep your own history.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Check the view's documentation for keys and retention.
2. Join on SubscriberKey and JobID where the view supports them.
3. Export long-term history to your own data extension.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Last-open date per subscriber: SELECT SubscriberKey, MAX(EventDate) FROM _Open GROUP BY SubscriberKey.

COMMON ERRORS

Assuming a data view keeps data forever.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is _Open used for and what limits apply?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

List the data views you would use for an engagement report and state each key and retention limit (verify on the docs).

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- SFMC data views (Salesforce docs)

Quick reference: SQL in SFMC

Area	Items
SQL in SFMC	SELECT, FROM, WHERE, GROUP BY, HAVING, ORDER BY, JOIN types, CASE WHEN, COUNT, SUM, AVG, MIN, MAX, ROW_NUMBER. Check the SFMC SQL restrictions before use.

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HANDBOOK 3

AMPscript, HTML email and CloudPages basics

Syntax, variables, data extension lookups, responsive email and the code explained line by line.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 8: Content Builder and Email Development

Level: Beginner to intermediate. Content Builder assets, responsive email design and dynamic content.

Module 8

8.1 Content Builder assets and naming

WHAT IS IT?

> Content Builder stores emails, images, content blocks and templates in folders. Naming conventions make assets findable and safe to reuse.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Teams lose time looking for assets, and reused blocks change without warning if the naming and sharing are wrong.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create folders by brand, campaign type and year.
2. Name blocks with a prefix such as blk_footer_brandA.
3. Use shared content blocks for footers and legal text.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> blk_footer_brandA is used in 40 emails; one edit updates them all.

COMMON ERRORS

Editing a shared block without checking every email that uses it.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you organise Content Builder for three brands?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a folder and naming structure for two brands.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

8.2 Responsive HTML email

WHAT IS IT?

Email HTML uses table-based layouts, inline CSS and media queries for mobile. Email clients have different support, so test in several clients.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

Most emails are opened on phones; a layout that breaks on mobile loses clicks.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use a single-column table layout with a maximum width of 600px.
2. Inline the key styles.
3. Use alt text on images and a text fallback for buttons.
4. Test on mobile and desktop clients.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

A two-column layout collapses to one column below 480px using a media query.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
<!DOCTYPE html>
<html>
<body style="margin:0;background:#f4f4f7;font-family:Arial,sans-serif">
<table role="presentation" width="100%" cellpadding="0" cellspacing="0"><tr><td align="center">
  <table role="presentation" width="600" style="max-width:600px;background:#ffffff">
    <tr><td style="padding:24px;text-align:center;font-size:22px;font-
weight:bold;color:#2b1a66">Your new offers</td></tr>
    <tr><td style="padding:0 24px 24px;font-size:16px;color:#1d1b2e">
      Hi %%=ProperCase(AttributeValue("FirstName"))=%%, here are picks for you.
    </td></tr>
    <tr><td align="center" style="padding:0 24px 32px">
      <a href="https://example.com/offer" style="background:#5b37c9;color:#ffffff;padding:12px
22px;text-decoration:none;border-radius:6px">See offers</a>
    </td></tr>
  </table>
</td></tr></table>
</body>
</html>
```

COMMON ERRORS

Relying on CSS features that many clients ignore.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Why are email layouts built with tables?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Build a 600px responsive promotional email with a header, hero, two columns and a button.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Campaign Monitor: HTML email guide

Module 9: AMPscript Programming

Level: Intermediate. AMPscript: syntax, variables, personalisation, data extension lookups and debugging.

Module 9

9.1 Syntax, variables and personalisation

WHAT IS IT?

> AMPscript runs on the server inside %%[...]%% blocks and prints values with %%=...=%%. SET assigns a variable; AttributeValue reads a subscriber attribute; ProperCase formats names.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Almost every personalised SFMC email or CloudPage uses AMPscript.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Declare with VAR and assign with SET.
2. Print with %%= ... =%%.
3. Use AttributeValue for subscriber fields and provide a default in IIF or a check.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Hello %%=ProperCase(AttributeValue("FirstName"))=%%.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
%%[
  VAR @first, @greeting
  SET @first = AttributeValue("FirstName")
  IF Empty(@first) THEN
    SET @greeting = "there"
  ELSE
    SET @greeting = ProperCase(@first)
  ENDIF
]%%
Hello %%=v(@greeting)=%%,
// Line by line: VAR declares the variables; SET reads the subscriber's first name;
// IF/ELSE chooses the fallback when the field is empty; v() prints the variable.
```

COMMON ERRORS

Printing an empty first name, which shows 'Hello ,'.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What does AttributeValue return if the attribute is missing?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a greeting that falls back to 'there' if FirstName is empty.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- AMPscript guide (Salesforce docs)

Module 9

9.2 Data extension lookups

WHAT IS IT?

> Lookup returns one value from a data extension by matching a field. LookupRows returns a set of rows. RowCount counts them. Always handle the case when nothing is found.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Lookups personalise messages from other data (orders, loyalty points) without a separate send.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Use Lookup('DataExtension','ReturnField','MatchField',value).
2. Check RowCount on LookupRows before looping.
3. Use the subscriber key or email address as the match value.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Show the loyalty points for the subscriber's email.

CODE EXAMPLE, WITH LINE-BY-LINE NOTES

```
%%[
  VAR @tier
  SET @tier = Lookup("LoyaltyMembers", "Tier", "EmailAddress", emailaddr)
  IF Empty(@tier) THEN SET @tier = "Member" ENDIF
]%%
Your tier: %%=v(@tier)=%%
// Lookup matches EmailAddress to the subscriber email (emailaddr); if no row, @tier is empty and
the default is used.
```

COMMON ERRORS

Lookup on a field that is not unique and returns a random row.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Explain Lookup and LookupRows.

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Show the loyalty tier with a Lookup and a default when no row exists.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- AMPscript guide (Salesforce docs)

Module 10: HTML, CSS and JavaScript for SFMC

Level: Beginner to intermediate. The web basics needed for emails and CloudPages, and where JavaScript is used in SFMC.

Module 10

10.1 HTML and CSS essentials for SFMC

WHAT IS IT?

> HTML gives structure (headings, paragraphs, links, images, tables, forms). CSS gives style (colours, spacing, fonts). In email, styles must be inlined and tables used for layout.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> You cannot fix a broken email or landing page without these basics.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Learn tags: h1, p, a, img, table, tr, td.
2. Learn selectors and properties.
3. Inline styles for email clients.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A link is an a tag with an href attribute.

COMMON ERRORS

Using div-based layouts in email.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is the difference between HTML and CSS?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Build a simple page with a heading, a paragraph and a link.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- MDN: HTML basics (official)

Module 10

10.2 JavaScript in CloudPages and forms

WHAT IS IT?

> JavaScript runs in the browser and can validate forms. Server-side JavaScript (SSJS) runs in SFMC for data work and is different from browser JavaScript. Keep secrets off the browser.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Forms and interactive pages need validation before data is saved.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Validate the email format before submit.
2. Show error messages next to fields.
3. Use SSJS only where the platform supports it and check the docs.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A registration form that checks the email format before posting.

COMMON ERRORS

Trusting browser validation alone; always validate on the server too.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

Where would you run JavaScript in an SFMC project?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a browser check for an email field.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

Quick reference: AMPscript

Area	Items
AMPscript functions	VAR, SET, IF/ELSEIF/ELSE/ENDIF, FOR, Lookup, LookupRows, LookupOrderedRows, RowCount, Row, Field, InsertDE, UpdateDE, UpsertDE, DeleteDE, AttributeValue, ProperCase, Concat, Substring, Empty, v().

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HANDBOOK 4

Journey Builder and Automation Studio

Entry sources, activities, splits, re-entry, testing, activities, scheduling and monitoring.

Salesforce Marketing Cloud (SFMC) Academy. Verify product names, editions, licences and certifications on Salesforce's official pages.

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Module 11: Journey Builder

Level: Intermediate. Journeys: entry sources, activities, splits, testing and troubleshooting.

Module 11

11.1 Entry sources and activities

WHAT IS IT?

> A journey starts with an entry source (data extension, API event, Salesforce data, audience) and moves contacts through activities: email, SMS, push, wait, decision splits, engagement splits, random splits and update contact.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Journeys deliver the multi-step experiences customers expect, from welcome series to renewal reminders.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Choose an entry source that updates in near real time for triggered journeys.
2. Add an email activity and a wait activity.
3. Add a decision split on a data field (for example, plan type).

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Welcome journey: entry on sign-up, welcome email, wait 2 days, decision split on first login.

COMMON ERRORS

Entering contacts from a data extension that is refreshed once a week and expecting real-time triggers.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

What is an entry source and how do you choose one?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Design a three-step welcome journey on paper with entry, email, wait and a split.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Journey Builder documentation (Salesforce)

Module 11

11.2 Re-entry, exit criteria and testing

WHAT IS IT?

> Re-entry rules decide whether a contact can enter again. Exit criteria stop contacts who have completed or unsubscribed. Test with a test data extension before activating.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> A wrong re-entry rule either floods a contact with messages or stops them from ever re-entering.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Set re-entry rules explicitly.
2. Add an exit on unsubscribe.
3. Test with a small test population, then review contact tracking.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Abandoned cart: re-entry allowed after 7 days, exit when the order completes.

COMMON ERRORS

Leaving re-entry at default without checking.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you troubleshoot a journey that does not accept contacts?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write the test plan for an abandoned cart journey.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Trailhead (free learning)

Module 12: Automation Studio

Level: Intermediate. Automations: SQL activities, file imports, scheduling and monitoring.

Module 12

12.1 Activities and scheduling

WHAT IS IT?

> An automation is a sequence of activities such as SQL Query, Data Extract, File Transfer, Import File, Filter, Script, Verification and send activities, run on a schedule or on file arrival.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Automations prepare audiences and keep data current without manual work.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Create the automation, add a SQL Query Activity, then a Data Extract if needed.
2. Set a schedule (daily at 02:00 for example).
3. Run once manually before scheduling.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> Daily: import file, run audience query, filter, then send.

COMMON ERRORS

Scheduling before testing the SQL; failures then happen unattended.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How would you schedule a daily audience build?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Plan an automation with four activities and an order.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Help: Marketing Cloud Engagement

Module 12

12.2 Monitoring, errors and retries

WHAT IS IT?

> Automation status shows which activity failed. Verification activities check files or row counts before the next step. Failure notifications and logs help support teams.

WHY IS IT IMPORTANT?

> Production failures need fast detection and a clear path back to working data.

HOW DOES IT WORK AND THE STEPS

1. Add a verification step after each import.
2. Set failure notifications to the owner.
3. Keep a rerun procedure.

REAL-WORLD EXAMPLE

> A verification step stops the send if the file has fewer than 1,000 rows.

COMMON ERRORS

No row-count checks, so an empty file sends an empty campaign.

INTERVIEW QUESTION

How do you troubleshoot an automation failure?

HANDS-ON EXERCISE

Write a runbook for a failed daily import.

OFFICIAL DOCUMENTATION AND FURTHER READING

- Salesforce Developer Documentation

Quick reference: Journey Builder and Automation Studio

Area	Items
Journey Builder	Entry sources (data extension, API event, Salesforce data, audience); activities (email, SMS, push, wait, update contact); splits (decision, engagement, random); exit criteria; re-entry rules.
Automation Studio	SQL Query, Data Extract, File Transfer, Import File, Filter, Script, Verification, send and wait activities; schedule and file-trigger starts.

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HANDBOOK 5

SFMC interview question bank

Technical, scenario and behavioural questions from the master prompt, linked to the modules that teach them.

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Interview questions

The full question bank from the master prompt. Each question is linked to the module that teaches it. Model answers are added in the next batch; use the module topic to build your answer.

SFMC fundamentals

1. What is SFMC?
2. Explain SFMC architecture.
3. What is a MID?
4. What is a business unit?
5. Explain contact key versus subscriber key.

Data extensions

1. What is a sendable data extension?
2. What is a primary key?
3. Explain data retention.
4. What is a shared data extension?

SQL

1. Explain SQL joins.
2. Write a query to identify inactive subscribers.
3. Explain ROW_NUMBER.
4. Explain data views.
5. How would you optimise a query?

Email Studio

1. Explain subscriber statuses.
2. What are send classifications?
3. Explain triggered sends.
4. What is suppression management?

AMPscript

1. What is AMPscript?
2. Explain Lookup and LookupRows.
3. Explain AttributeValue.
4. Write a personalised email.
5. How do you troubleshoot AMPscript errors?

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Journey Builder

1. Explain entry sources.
2. What is a Decision Split?
3. What is an Engagement Split?
4. Explain journey re-entry.
5. How do you troubleshoot journey entry failures?

Automation Studio

1. Explain SQL Query Activity.
2. What is a File Transfer Activity?
3. How do you create a scheduled automation?
4. How do you troubleshoot automation failures?

CloudPages

1. What are CloudPages?
2. Explain RequestParameter.
3. How do you capture form data?
4. How do you protect customer information?

APIs

1. Explain REST versus SOAP.
2. What is OAuth 2.0?
3. What are installed packages?
4. How do you integrate an external system?

Architecture

1. Design a multi-business-unit SFMC solution.
2. Explain customer data architecture.
3. How do you integrate Sales Cloud and SFMC?
4. How would you design an enterprise marketing automation platform?

AI

1. How can AI improve marketing automation?
2. Explain predictive personalisation.
3. How can an AI assistant integrate with SFMC?
4. How do you ensure customer data security?

Scenarios

1. A campaign has a high bounce rate. How do you investigate?

2. An email send failed. What steps would you take?
3. A journey is not accepting new contacts. How do you troubleshoot?
4. A customer receives duplicate emails. How would you identify the root cause?
5. A SQL query is returning duplicate records. How would you fix it?
6. An automation failed during a production run. How would you handle it?
7. A business needs customer data from multiple systems. How would you design the integration?
8. A customer wants personalised communications across email and SMS. How would you build the journey?

Behavioural

1. Tell me about yourself.
2. Describe an SFMC implementation.
3. Explain a difficult production issue.
4. Describe a technical problem you solved.
5. How do you handle stakeholders?
6. How do you manage urgent campaign requests?
7. Explain your approach to testing and quality.

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HANDBOOK 6

Capstone projects and portfolio

Eight project briefs and the portfolio standard.

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Capstone projects

Eight projects. Each must include the sections below and a demo video. The full workbook with templates and rubrics follows in the next batch.

Project 1: End-to-end email marketing automation

Customer data, segmentation, email design, AMPscript, campaign execution and performance reporting.

Project 2: Customer onboarding journey

Customer data, Journey Builder, email, SMS, decision splits and performance tracking.

Project 3: E-commerce abandoned cart automation

Transactional data, SQL segmentation, journey entry, personalised recommendations and multi-channel follow-up.

Project 4: Customer retention and re-engagement

Engagement analysis with SQL and data views, segmentation, journey automation and KPI measurement.

Project 5: Enterprise Customer 360

CRM data, contact model, data extensions, integration, Data Cloud architecture and unified profiles.

Project 6: API-driven marketing automation

API architecture, authentication, external system integration, triggered messaging and error handling.

Project 7: Advanced personalisation engine

Customer behaviour, AMPscript, dynamic content, segmentation and personalised journeys.

Project 8: AI-powered marketing automation platform

SFMC data, AI integration, segmentation, campaign recommendations, automated reporting, human approval, security and monitoring.

Every project must include

1. Business problem
2. Target users
3. Project scope
4. Functional requirements
5. Non-functional requirements

6. Solution architecture
7. Data model
8. Data flow diagram
9. Technology stack
10. Implementation steps
11. SQL and AMPscript code where applicable
12. Testing
13. Screenshots or demo evidence
14. KPIs
15. Business impact
16. Limitations
17. Future enhancements
18. Technical documentation
19. Portfolio presentation
20. Demo video

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HANDBOOK 7

12-month SFMC learning roadmap

Seven stages with study time, milestones and assessments.

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12-month learning roadmap

A realistic plan for a beginner studying part time. Adjust the hours to your time. The programme makes no promise of employment or any salary.

Stage	Topics	Study time	Practical milestone	Assessment
Stage 1 · Months 1 to 2	CRM and marketing fundamentals, Salesforce ecosystem, SFMC basics (Modules 1 to 3)	About 8 hours a week	Lifecycle map, metrics calculations, business unit design	Explain the lifecycle and metrics in an interview-style answer
Stage 2 · Months 3 to 4	Contacts, data architecture, data extensions, import and cleaning (Modules 4 and 5)	About 10 hours a week	Customer data extension with keys and a clean import	Import a file with planted duplicates and fix it
Stage 3 · Months 5 to 6	SQL for SFMC, HTML and CSS, JavaScript basics, AMPscript (Modules 6, 9 and 10)	About 12 hours a week	Ten SQL queries, a responsive email, ten AMPscript personalisations	Code review and a timed SQL test
Stage 4 · Months 7 to 8	Email Studio, Content Builder, Journey Builder, Automation Studio (Modules 7, 8, 11 and 12)	About 12 hours a week	Welcome journey, abandoned cart journey, scheduled automation	Journey and automation walkthrough
Stage 5 · Months 9 to 10	CloudPages, Mobile Studio, personalisation, analytics, APIs and integrations (Modules 13 to 18)	About 12 hours a week	CloudPage form, REST integration, API-triggered email	API demo with Postman and error handling
Stage 6 · Month 11	Data Cloud, advanced automation, security, deliverability, testing and architecture (Modules 19 to 23)	About 10 hours a week	Architecture document and a troubleshooting report	Architecture presentation and scenario answers
Stage 7 · Month 12	AI in marketing, capstone projects, portfolio, interviews and certification planning (Modules 24, 26 to 28)	About 15 hours a week	Two capstone projects published with demo videos	Three mock interviews and a certification plan

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HANDBOOK 8

SFMC quick reference

SQL, AMPscript, data views, Journey Builder, Automation Studio, deliverability, APIs and troubleshooting.

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Quick reference

Area	Items
SQL in SFMC	SELECT, FROM, WHERE, GROUP BY, HAVING, ORDER BY, JOIN types, CASE WHEN, COUNT, SUM, AVG, MIN, MAX, ROW_NUMBER. Check the SFMC SQL restrictions before use.
AMPscript functions	VAR, SET, IF/ELSEIF/ELSE/ENDIF, FOR, Lookup, LookupRows, LookupOrderedRows, RowCount, Row, Field, InsertDE, UpdateDE, UpsertDE, DeleteDE, AttributeValue, ProperCase, Concat, Substring, Empty, v().
Data views	_Subscribers, _Sent, _Open, _Click, _Bounce, _Unsubscribe, _Job, _Journey, _JourneyActivity, _SMSMessageTracking, _Complaint, _BusinessUnitUnsubscribes. Keys and retention limits are in the official data view documentation.
Journey Builder	Entry sources (data extension, API event, Salesforce data, audience); activities (email, SMS, push, wait, update contact); splits (decision, engagement, random); exit criteria; re-entry rules.
Automation Studio	SQL Query, Data Extract, File Transfer, Import File, Filter, Script, Verification, send and wait activities; schedule and file-trigger starts.
Deliverability	SPF (authorised senders), DKIM (signature), DMARC (policy and reports), hard and soft bounces, complaints, suppression, sender and domain reputation, inbox placement.
APIs	REST (JSON over HTTP), SOAP (XML with WSDL), OAuth 2.0 client credentials, installed package, access token, bearer header, scopes, rate limits, pagination, webhooks.
Troubleshooting checklist	Confirm impact; check the error and the log; check recent changes; reproduce with a test contact; check data and keys; fix; verify; document the root cause.

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